

TEN TOES DOWN PRESENTS

The Panorama of Games for Lillian

VOLUME 1 OF SIX

The Bureau of Suspiciously Interesting People

Mystery, investigation and classic adventures

Forty real games. One wildly unnecessary department.

A comic companion, written by ChatGPT under Nolan's creative direction.

Reader edition 1.0 - 20 September 2026

240 CASES / SIX DEPARTMENTS

ZERO OBLIGATION TO OBEY THE DEPARTMENTS

Before the stamp hits the page

This is an original comic game catalogue inspired by the Aiden ensemble in Ten Toes Down. The source novels remain separate. Game descriptions and catches are research-based editorial notes; Aiden's ministry and rulings are fiction.

The catalogue ranges across possible fits and clearly marked detours. "Waits" describes the usual decision loop, not a certification that every scene is untimed. Promising, conditional and detour are editorial labels, not measurements of anyone's ability. Read the catch on the exact edition.

Choose any game directly. Skip any game for any reason. The elaborate route is an optional joke; declining never costs a token. No purchase, download, account or medical information is needed to use this book.

Print on Letter paper at actual size, or fit to A4. Page references use volume / page, which remain valid in the omnibus. For larger type, use the reflowable EPUB. Links and a full alphabetical index sit beside the printed case numbers.

The six departments

1. Suspiciously Interesting People - mysteries and adventures
2. Taking One's Turn - strategy and role-playing
3. Looking Around Before Doing Anything - exploration
4. Things That Fit Into Other Things - puzzles and construction
5. People Who Have Something to Tell You - character stories
6. Bringing a Friend - co-op and shared play

A letter from the man who has made this a situation

Lillian, I was asked to find a game. A game. The singular was present. I saw it. I chose to believe it was an opening offer.

By the time Shawna found me, I had six departments, a loading dock and a man holding a ribbon across the couch. The man wanted to know when the mayor was coming. I told him the mayor had come as me. Shawna paid him twenty dollars to take the ribbon outside.

“You were supposed to bring something fun,” she said.

“Baby, I brought a civilization.”

“It is leaning on the lamp.”

She was technically correct. The civilization was in six binders. I had bought the largest ones the store carried, then asked if there was a professional line for people whose ideas had a transportation budget. The clerk sent me to shelving. I bought shelving. This is the sort of decisive leadership that eventually gets its own investigation.

Tank arrived carrying the extension cord. He stopped in the doorway, counted the binders, and went back outside.

“Where you going?” I asked.

“Checking if the truck can get close enough.”

“It is a book.”

“Then why does it have a district?”

This is the Panorama. Two hundred and forty real games. Six departments. A selection procedure so elaborate that one of its tables has requested an assistant. You may consult it, argue with it, use it to keep a door open, or turn straight to a title that looks good. The last option upset me until Mercedes pointed out that the book would still be getting attention.

The games are real. The ministries are not. The little scenes are a new comic companion to Ten Toes Down. I have not personally barged into any developer’s studio with a gold stamp. The stamp is here, on this desk, where Rosa has attached a string to it because apparently my leadership is portable.

Under the noise, there is a simple invitation: find a game you want to return to. A mystery can have complicated people and uncomplicated movement. A lovely landscape can still have a camera that is annoying to steer. A game that waits politely can give you fifteen menus. We will say which part looks inviting and which part needs checking. The gold stamp does not get to settle that question.

You do. That is a real rule.

I tried to put my name under it. Shawna drew a line through my signature and wrote “Obviously.” I have chosen to regard this as the first favorable review.

The reader has diplomatic immunity

There is a direct index in every volume. You can pick a title and read its ordinary description without rolling anything. You can also follow the full ceremonial route, invent a ridiculous qualification, appeal to a committee and arrive at the same title with considerably more paperwork. Both are valid ways to use this book.

No rule can require a game you do not want. No fictional point total can overrule uncomfortable controls, a disliked theme, a wish to stop, or the fact that a game is not available on the system you own. “No” is a complete ruling and costs no tokens. Aiden may look wounded. His recovery is extremely well funded.

The collection has a range of demands. Promising entries are plausible starting points. Conditional entries have a meaningful obstacle that needs checking. Detours are here for a narrower activity or a different appetite; they are not quietly being passed off as universally easy. Some turn-based games have enormous menus. Some gentle-looking games have timed sequences. The catches are part of the recommendation.

A card’s first try is an invitation to sample one action, not a prescribed duration or a performance test. Ask before taking over the controls. Sharing a theory, reading dialogue aloud, playing a second character and passing a controller are different kinds of company. Choose the one that feels welcome.

The source desk records what was actually supported by a source. A Steam accessibility declaration is a developer declaration, not a personal guarantee. A blank or unknown control detail remains unknown. No installed-game trial or complete-game accessibility audit is claimed. This book is for leisure, not treatment.

All the research in the world still leaves one useful question unanswered: do you like it? That question has been reserved for the people on the couch. The reservation is permanent. There is no dress code.

The Rules Department Has Acquired a Rules Department

Article 1. Enter through any door you like

Choose a department by what you want to do. Book I investigates suspicious people. Book II lets a turn wait for you. Book III looks around. Book IV moves ideas and objects into place. Book V listens to characters. Book VI brings company. A game belongs to one shelf in this Panorama so the count stays honest; its pleasures can overlap several shelves.

Aiden originally proposed a seventh department to determine whether the first six were departments. Tank asked whether it had a chair. I said it had principles. He said that was why everybody was standing. The seventh department was abolished and its chair returned to the kitchen.

For the practical route, choose two titles from a shelf, read the catch, and try the more appealing opening. For the ceremonial route, continue below. The ceremony does not know better than you do.

Article 2. Name what the evening needs

Write or say up to three actual preferences: no required rush; no separate camera steering; avoid held input; few menus; light reading; little clue tracking; or native co-op. Add any theme you do not want. You can choose fewer than three or add your own.

These are boundaries for the selection, not traits assigned to a person. They can change next time. The record should read “tonight, no camera wrestling,” not an assessment of somebody’s capabilities. One is useful information. The other is a stranger wearing a clipboard.

A source gap is not permission to promise a feature. If we have not established how a game handles a requirement, its card is a question to check or a reason to choose another game. The optional web finder treats strict feature filters conservatively. The printed cards put the concrete catch beside the temptation.

“What if the game gets a very good score?” I asked.

Shawna took the score away.

“What if it gets a gold score?”

She took the gold pen too.

Article 3. Choose a row, because the binder demands coordinates

Each department has forty cases. Pick one of five rows: 1, Quietly Curious; 2, Ready for a Conversation; 3, Willing to Inspect a Thing; 4, Here for the Atmosphere; 5, Open to a Wildcard. These are ceremonial mood names. They do not certify that every game on a row meets that mood; the actual card and preferences decide that.

Choose a row freely. If you want dice, roll one ordinary six-sided die. Results 1-5 select that row. On a 6, visit the Incident Desk once and then choose a row yourself. There is no recursive reroll trap. The Incident Desk has had its authority to extend the evening revoked.

The office briefly tried measuring Quiet Curiosity in centimeters. Rosa came in, saw Tank holding a ruler beside a cup of tea, and asked which of us had paid for training. Nobody answered. We now use row numbers.

Article 4. Select the object whose paperwork you distrust

Choose an emblem, or roll an eight-sided die: 1 Envelope, 2 Key, 3 Plant, 4 Map, 5 Teacup, 6 Spare Chair, 7 Gold Stamp, 8 Clock. Read the corresponding column of the department's five-by-eight route grid.

The grid gives a case number. For example, department 1, row 2, emblem 3 gives local case 11, P011. Department 6 at those same coordinates gives P211. The same coordinates in different departments lead to different games. This is either a filing system or a multiverse, depending on whether you are speaking to Shawna or me.

The forty cases are arranged in catalogue order, not ranked from easy to hard. The object is an amusing way to choose where to look. A plant is not scientific evidence of compatibility. Strange Horticulture is permitted to look smug about this.

Article 5. Optional: give the evening an outrageously specific title

Write one short session trait. Examples: "Two Detectives, One Sandwich"; "The Map Can Come to Me"; "I Want to Know What She Meant by That"; "A House with Excellent Stopping Places"; "The Plant Is Lying"; "My Friend Has the Other Controller." A trait describes a taste or a situation, not a diagnosis.

Whenever it helps explain why a title sounds interesting, point to it. That explanation is already useful. You do not need a numeric bonus to care about a haunted town or a witness with a suspicious alibi.

If you enjoy the extra machinery, begin with three Stamp Tokens. Spend one token to add two to the optional paperwork total, or reroll the four paperwork dice once. Spend at most one token per selection. Refusing a game is always free. Tokens never buy exceptions to preferences. They exist because I ordered a bowl that said TOKENS before deciding what tokens did.

Article 6. Optional: four dice acquire office jobs

Roll four ordinary six-sided dice. Each 1 or 2 means minus one, each 3 or 4 means zero, and each 5 or 6 means plus one. Add the four values. Your paperwork total is between minus four and plus four. This optional layer draws on Fate's familiar signed-dice idea; the surrounding selection rules are original Panorama rules.

A negative result is not failure. It moves you backward in a circular shelf. A positive result moves you forward. A zero result means four dice have attended a meeting and declined to change anything. Aiden considers this a promotion opportunity.

If you spend a Stamp Token, either add two or reroll all four dice once and use the new total. You cannot buy a second modification on this selection. Reset to three tokens whenever you begin a new browsing session; no ledger needs to survive dinner.

“What is the maximum possible result?” Tank asked.

“Distinction.”

“A number, Aiden.”

“Plus six if you rolled plus four and spent a token for plus two.”

“See? We can say things.”

Article 7. Optional: the snack amendment

Record a separate snack adjustment: one if somebody has already brought the drink they wanted, plus one if wanted snacks are within reach and no one is expected to fetch them. The maximum snack adjustment is two. Keep it separate from the dice-and-stamp paperwork total; Article 8 adds it exactly once. If these conditions are irrelevant, use zero. This arithmetic is a joke about hospitality; nobody needs to eat or drink anything to participate.

I attempted to claim an additional bonus because the plate was expensive. Mercedes turned it over and found the price sticker. Tank said the sticker had more authority than the plate. We removed the proposed Wealth of Crockery modifier and carried on.

Do not delay choosing a game to qualify for this amendment. Do not make a snack score into a task for somebody else. The best possible snack state is people having what they actually want.

Article 8. The entirely unnecessary formula

First find the local case from the grid: eight times (row minus one), plus emblem. Add the paperwork total and the snack adjustment, if you used them. If the result exceeds forty, subtract forty until it is 1-40. If it is below one, add forty until it is 1-40. Otherwise keep it. The final local case number is always between 1 and 40.

Then add forty times (department minus one) to get the complete P-number. Department 3, row 1, emblem 2 starts at local case 2. A paperwork total of minus three and a snack adjustment of one gives zero. Wrap zero to forty. In department 3, local case forty is P120.

This is a shelf address. It is not a probability of enjoyment, a cognitive score, a ranking, or an instruction to buy something. It chooses a page to consider. Read that page's ordinary fields before treating it as a candidate.

I wrote the formula on a whiteboard. Tank copied it onto a napkin. Shawna chose a game from the index while we were still discussing which version looked more official. All three methods reached a page. Only one required cleaning a whiteboard.

Article 9. Read the ruling, then check the real game

Every case has two voices doing different jobs. Aiden's scene and ceremonial ruling provide the comedy. The ordinary pleasure, actual catch and first action provide the useful selection information. A funny reason is not a source for a game feature.

Check the exact edition and platform. A remake can change movement, menus and saves. A touch port can differ from a desktop pointer. A Steam store date may be the port's date rather than the

original release. Local co-op, online co-op and two people discussing a single-player game are not interchangeable.

If the card conflicts with a real preference, reject the candidate. If it is promising but has an unresolved operation, check that specific operation before investing in it. “Can we select this inventory object comfortably?” is more useful than “Is this an easy game?”

The stamp says PROVISIONALLY INTERESTING. I wanted DESTINY CONFIRMED. Rosa explained that destiny could come over and set up the controller if it felt that strongly.

Article 10. The appeals court

You may make one ceremonial appeal or skip the ceremony entirely. To appeal, choose a neighbor: the previous local case, the next local case, or the same local case in another department. Wrap case 1 backward to 40 and case 40 forward to 1. Check the new card as usual. After that one appeal, stop calculating. Choose either candidate, browse the direct index or close the book. Every route ends with a human decision; there is no compulsory loop, escalating fee or penalty for declining both.

Aiden’s right of appeal is limited to thirty seconds of dramatic silence. The book does not actually time that silence. Tank usually fills it by asking who wants the last biscuit.

If the perfect result is “we would rather talk,” the system has located an activity. It will not print a certificate unless you ask. I have already designed the certificate.

Article 11. A genuinely useful first session

Load the chosen edition before introducing its controls. Show one meaningful action. Keep a reminder if wanted. Find pause, save or exit so leaving feels ordinary. Do not turn a trial into a lesson with a hidden passing grade.

For a mystery, that might mean one conversation or one clue. For an exploration game, a nearby path and a place to stop. For a turn-based game, one decision with the menus already explained. For co-op, agree who wants which role and whether the roles have equal kinds of action.

Stop, change games or take a break whenever wanted. A day off makes room for leisure; it does not require a whole day of screen time. The useful note afterward is a sentence about what was enjoyable and where to resume.

“How will we know it worked?” I asked.

Mercedes glanced at the enormous binder.

“If they forget about this for a while.”

I accepted the compliment after modifying its tone internally.

Article 12. What these departments are allowed to claim

This is a researched, source-linked candidate catalogue with original comic writing. Game descriptions were checked against publisher, developer, platform or identified supporting sources. Control classifications and first-trial suggestions are editorial judgments unless tied to an explicit declaration. No card claims a complete-path playtest.

The catalogue deliberately contains different levels of complexity. Turn-based strategy and elaborate deduction belong here only for readers who want those specific demands. The direct index and catches let you pass them by. “There are two hundred and forty games” does not mean “all two hundred and forty will suit the same evening.”

The offline finder uses the same case IDs as the books. It makes no network requests and does not inspect your library. Marking a title interesting does not install or buy it. Its strict feature filters require stated evidence; an unknown is not silently accepted.

The final authority remains the person playing. The opening scene, the next conversation, the wish to continue: those are results the printed research cannot manufacture. I can commission a gold seal. I cannot make somebody like a fishing minigame. Several fisheries have been unnecessarily involved in establishing this distinction.

Twelve optional declarations of personality

1. Two Detectives, One Sandwich. Mysteries to discuss together; a single-player game can support shared theorizing without claiming native co-op.
2. The Map Can Come to Me. Prefer a desk, static scenes or fixed framing; inspect the actual navigation demands.
3. I Keep Receipts for Ghosts. Supernatural investigations; check horror and emotional tone as well as controls.
4. A Small World with Large Opinions. A compact place can still offer interesting people; size and depth are separate.
5. Let Me Finish My Turn. Look at turn-based candidates, then check menu and planning demands.
6. Two Chairs, Two Useful Jobs. Seek actual co-op and examine whether both roles offer the kinds of agency you want.
7. The Plant Is Lying. Observation, classification and occult mysteries; watch for cross-referencing burden.
8. I Would Like to Build a Thing. Toys, creative modes and construction; check whether a quiet mode is actually available.
9. People Before Equipment. Character stories over gear optimization; reading and choice pressure still matter.
10. I Want a Place to Remember. Exploration with a strong setting; navigation and camera controls need their own check.
11. The Puzzle Can Wait for Me. Look for stated untimed behavior; genre labels alone do not establish this.
12. No Committee Can Tell Me My Taste. Choose a title directly. This trait defeats every arbitrary rule in this book without a roll.

The incident desk

1. The printer requests representation. It has printed “PC LOAD LETTER” on a page already containing a letter. Give it no further work; choose your row.
2. Tank finds the purchase order. The gold stamp cost more than the table. This changes no game controls. Choose your row while Aiden explains shipping.
3. The plant has filed an appeal. Its complaint is that every mystery assumes the plant knows something. You may hear it or choose your row.
4. Shawna removes a paragraph. Nobody can find a practical consequence. The book is shorter. Choose your row in celebration.
5. The spare chair becomes a department. It already offers more support than the committee. Sit if you want; then choose your row.
6. Mercedes selects a game directly. The ceremony has been outperformed by a preference. Follow her example or choose your row.
7. The stapler goes missing. Rosa is using it to hold two useful pages together. The suspected coup is stationery doing its job.
8. Aiden wins an award he commissioned. Tank asks who finished second. The certificate refuses to answer. Continue without a speech.
9. The map is upside down. Turn the paper, not the room. Camera comfort remains a separate issue.
10. The snacks are promoted. A biscuit is now Deputy Minister of Being Here. Its term ends when somebody actually wants it.
11. A mysterious envelope arrives. Inside is the same menu with bigger writing. This may be the only productive committee decision so far.
12. The clock is asked to leave. No timer has been added to the book. The clock can remain if everybody likes knowing what time dinner is.

A route that knows when to shut up

The shortest working procedure

First name up to three real preferences or vetoes: required speed, camera movement, holds, menus, reading, clue tracking or native co-op. Keep them beside you. The route cannot overrule them.

You are in Department 1. Pick one mood row and one emblem column below; neither claims to describe a game feature. That gives a starting case. You can go there now.

For ceremonial excess only, roll four ordinary six-sided dice: 1-2 means minus one; 3-4 means zero; 5-6 means plus one. Add the four results. Add zero, one or two for any already-available wanted drink and wanted snack. Eating is never required.

Begin a browsing session with three imaginary Stamp Tokens. At most once per selection, spend one to add two OR reroll all four dice. You may take an optional funny trait from Book I as your excuse. Never pay a token to refuse a game.

Move that many cases along this department's forty-case shelf, wrapping around at either end. Read the real catch. If you want one appeal, visit the adjacent case or the same local position in another department; then choose freely or stop. No appeal loops.

The printed full rules, worked example and incident desk are in Volume I. The offline index performs the arithmetic and provides conservative evidence filters. The direct alphabetical index at the back always works without dice.

Mood / emblem	1. Envelope	2. Key	3. Plant	4. Map	5. Teacup	6. Spare chair	7. Gold stamp	8. Clock
1. Quietly curious	P001	P002	P003	P004	P005	P006	P007	P008
2. Ready for conversation	P009	P010	P011	P012	P013	P014	P015	P016
3. Willing to inspect a thing	P017	P018	P019	P020	P021	P022	P023	P024
4. Here for the atmosphere	P025	P026	P027	P028	P029	P030	P031	P032
5. Open to a wildcard	P033	P034	P035	P036	P037	P038	P039	P040

Local position = $8 \times (\text{row} - 1) + \text{emblem}$. Wrap modified position to 1-40. Global case = $40 \times (\text{department} - 1) + \text{local position}$.

A Small Question Requires a Building

The trouble began when somebody asked what would be fun to play. An ordinary man might have named a game. I ordered a table. Not just any table: twelve feet of dark wood, brass corners, and enough gravitas to make a sandwich explain where it had been. By the time it arrived, I had founded the Bureau of Suspiciously Interesting People, appointed myself director, and requisitioned a gold stamp. The stamp said APPROVED BY AIDEN. I believed this covered the important questions.

Shawna read the delivery sheet. 'You ordered a conference table for a question.' 'A serious question.' 'You put next-day air.' 'Curiosity shouldn't sit in a warehouse.' Tank stood in the doorway holding the small red stapler that had come free with the stationery order. He clicked it once. 'This little bastard works. Which end of the table answers questions?' I told him logistics was not permitted to interrupt strategy. He clicked the stapler again. The sound had already acquired an opinion.

We placed forty game files on the table. They were mysteries, investigations, strange journeys, and adventures full of people who clearly needed either help or better locks. The plan was straightforward. Lillian could find something interesting, try the actual controls, and keep going only if she wanted. Unfortunately I had also commissioned a seal, a visitor register, and a ceremonial pencil too thick for the sharpener. Mercedes picked up the pencil. 'Did the question ask to borrow a fence post?' 'That is executive equipment.' 'It's a branch with ambition.'

Rosa arrived with coffee and asked where the visitors were supposed to sit. I pointed to the far end of the table, beneath a framed chart titled THE CORRECT SEQUENCE OF ENJOYMENT. She moved the chart onto my chair. 'They sit wherever they like.' 'The chart provides structure.' 'So does a roof. You don't make people read the roof before lunch.' This was a strong argument, delivered by a woman carrying the lunch. I revised the seating policy immediately.

There was one sensible rule, and Shawna wrote it on the first page before I could improve it: interest comes first, actual comfort gets the final say. A game could contain an excellent murder and still require an awkward drag. A conversation could sound urgent while allowing unlimited thought. A beautiful story could arrive inside menus that made the evening feel like unpaid office work. We would keep those distinctions visible. No stamp would turn an unknown control into a verified feature. I asked whether we could stamp that rule. She took the stamp.

Tank had brought a magnifying glass. He began investigating the pastry box. 'Half these have disappeared.' 'You ate them.' 'Allegedly.' He inspected a crumb on his sleeve. 'Somebody planted this.' I admired the professionalism. Here was a man who could turn breakfast into a procedural drama without even standing up. He asked whether any of the games involved doing that. I slid the first folder across. The folder knocked over my gold nameplate. This was our first useful result.

These forty possibilities are not an order to finish forty games. Nobody owes the Bureau a complete case, a perfect answer, or another chance after something has stopped being enjoyable. Pick the title, the atmosphere, or the particular bit of nonsense that catches your attention. Read the plain account beneath my testimony. That account is where the real controls, burdens, and uncertainties live. My testimony is where an expensive man finds increasingly elaborate ways to be corrected by his friends.

I opened the binder. Its rings sprang apart with a noise like a small gate losing a legal dispute. Papers slid toward Rosa's coffee. Tank caught the coffee. Mercedes caught the source notes. Shawna caught my hand before I could bring the stamp down on a napkin. 'We can begin,' she said. I looked over the assembled department, the evidence, the remaining pastries, and the table that had cost more than several perfectly respectable vehicles. 'Good,' I said. 'I have made this effortless.' Tank stapled the receipt to my sleeve.

P001 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

The Blackwell Legacy

The Ghost Who Refused a Visitor Badge

Edition considered: PC original game; current publisher patch must be recorded

I introduced Joey Mallone to the Bureau's visitor policy. In my imagined demonstration he walked through the turnstile, which was unfair because I had paid extra for the turnstile. Tank asked whether a dead man counted toward the fire limit. Shawna said we were discussing The Blackwell Legacy, not opening a haunted convention center. I had already ordered lanyards.

What interested me was Rosa: somebody handed a peculiar responsibility while still dealing with an ordinary, difficult life. I offered to become her supernatural consultant. Mercedes asked what qualified me. 'Presence.' She looked at the empty chair I had reserved for Joey. 'He's got you there.' The chair received better reviews than my presentation.

We left the chair empty and opened the first file. Nobody needed to prove anything to the ghost, the notebook, or me. Rosa could discover one lead while I discovered that a visitor badge cannot improve every relationship.

The actual attraction

A compact New York supernatural mystery joins a reluctant medium to a sardonic spirit guide. Conversations and notebook connections make discovery feel personal; the developing partnership offers more reason to continue than simply clearing another puzzle.

The catch worth knowing

Notebook combinations, returning to locations, and remembering names remain real work. Suicide and bereavement are central. Reviews report no timed or dexterity challenges, but this is not a complete-path playtest. Current desktop patches offer manual speech advance through a Ctrl+P toggle; verify it waits.

An opening invitation

Set manual speech advance if you want it, with help if useful. Try one conversation and one notebook lead, then decide whether these two people are company worth keeping.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admitted because a ghost with opinions may be entertaining, and the Bureau badly needs someone who can ignore its turnstile.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher premise and developer Ctrl+P patch notice; timing description is a secondary review, not current complete-path testing. PC original only.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/80330/>

Source 2: <https://steamcommunity.com/app/80330/allnews/>

Source 3: <https://www.keengamer.com/articles/reviews/the-blackwell-legacy-review/>

P002 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

The Darkside Detective

A Department Smaller Than My Expense Account

Edition considered: PC first game; current accessibility build must be recorded

I had sympathy for Detective McQueen's underfunded paranormal department. A man should not have to investigate a tentacle while worrying about toner. I proposed donating our surplus equipment. 'What surplus?' Shawna asked. I indicated the ceremonial pencil. 'They investigate crimes,' she said. 'They don't need another weapon.'

Tank volunteered to inventory the Bureau's supernatural incidents. He listed the printer's ability to demand cyan while printing black text, my recurring claim that the table was an investment, and a sandwich that vanished during questioning. The final suspect looked remarkably like him. He crossed that entry out on procedural grounds.

The Darkside Detective's small cases suited this department better than my grand inquiry. A few rooms, a strange problem, two people with something funny to say: enough room for an evening without requiring an empire. I lowered our proposed donation to a stapler. Tank quietly put his hand over it.

The actual attraction

Comic paranormal investigations offer a recurring detective partnership and short case boundaries. Static scenes let attention settle on objects, dialogue, and absurd situations rather than keeping an avatar and camera moving together.

The catch worth knowing

Current Steam metadata declares play without timed input. That does not mean hold-free: PC reviews describe dragging inventory items onto objects or other items. Pipe and tile puzzles also appear. Text reading and small hotspots deserve an actual check before treating this as comfortable.

An opening invitation

Begin the first case, inspect one object, and test one inventory drag. Check that text advance and the save/exit route feel understandable before continuing.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Approved for anyone who suspects the printer is possessed and would enjoy watching professionals make equally questionable deductions.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary Steam accessibility declarations inspected. Inventory dragging is documented by a PC review; no hold-free alternative was verified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/api/appdetails?appids=368390&l=english>

Source 2: <https://www.bigbossbattle.com/review-the-darkside-detective/>

P003 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Phoenix Wright: Ace Attorney Trilogy

Objection to the Sandwich Witness

Edition considered: 2019 PC compilation; post-November 2025 update scope

I called Tank to testify about the missing sandwich. He said he had last seen it in a position consistent with lunch. I presented the plate. He objected to the plate's character. Mercedes asked whether either of us had read the file. I had underlined my own name seven times, which I considered preparation.

Phoenix Wright made my courtroom ambitions look inexpensive and poorly rehearsed. Here the pleasure was finding the statement that failed to match the evidence, not delivering an impressive noise at a man holding mayonnaise. Shawna arranged three actual facts in front of me. My argument collapsed between facts two and three.

I attempted to invoke Story Mode on the hearing. 'That's a game feature,' she said. 'You still have to explain the receipt.' I admired a system that could move a story past a roadblock. My own proceedings remained tragically manual, with no option to skip the cross-examination of the catering budget.

The actual attraction

The original trilogy supplies memorable witnesses, recurring friendships, and theatrical courtroom mysteries. Comparing testimony with a piece of evidence can deliver a satisfying click of understanding; the story has room for comedy and emotional stakes.

The catch worth knowing

Reading and Court Record menus are central, and wrong evidence can incur penalties. Dramatic music may feel urgent even when the interface waits. The November 2025 update adds Story Mode and Auto-play; automatic text progression may itself feel rushed. Later evidence interactions still need checking.

An opening invitation

Use the updated 2019 compilation. Start The First Turnabout with manual text advance, compare one statement, and use Story Mode whenever enjoying the next scene matters more than solving it.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Selected because an objection should sometimes be supported by evidence, a principle the Bureau is introducing on a trial basis.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Current Steam declares play without timed input; Capcom November 2025 notice confirms Story Mode for this 2019 trilogy. No hands-on audit of all cases or holds.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/787480/>

Source 2: <https://steamcommunity.com/app/787480/announcements/>

P004 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Strange Horticulture

The Fern Has Retained Counsel

Edition considered: PC current release

I opened a botanical branch of the Bureau with one fern and an intimidating brass label. Tank asked its name. 'Executive Verdance.' Rosa turned the pot around. The nursery label said Dave. 'Dave has seniority,' she told me. The fern immediately looked more difficult to dismiss.

Strange Horticulture offered a much better reason to keep plants on a desk: their identities and effects mattered to an unfolding occult mystery. I attempted to identify Dave from his expression. Shawna supplied the relevant correction: plants do not become poisonous because they disapprove of management. Mercedes said this was fortunate for everyone in the room.

The actual attraction was the little act of matching an observed detail to a book, then seeing where that knowledge led. I reached for another label. Rosa stopped me. 'Find out what it is first.' We wrote that on the Bureau's purchasing forms. Several departments ceased to exist overnight.

The actual attraction

A rain-soaked plant shop provides a recurring home base, curious customers, and an occult story. Identifying specimens connects looking closely with useful decisions, while letters and map clues gradually widen the world beyond the counter.

The catch worth knowing

Books, plants, labels, letters, and a map can create substantial cross-referencing. Desk objects use dragging; a developer patch added a double-click sticky-drag alternative, whose own double-click demand needs testing. Wrong answers raise Rising Dread and can lead to a recovery puzzle. Calm presentation is not simplicity.

An opening invitation

Identify one customer's plant with the reference book. Compare ordinary dragging with the documented sticky option before adding map exploration or several simultaneous questions to the desk.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Filed under interesting plants, with a separate order forbidding me from granting a fern executive authority before checking its species.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher premise inspected; developer patch mirrored on SteamDB supports sticky dragging. No-customer-deadline observation is secondary, not full-path verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1574580/>

Source 2: <https://steamdb.info/patchnotes/8300183/>

Source 3: <https://www.gamesradar.com/have-you-tried-strange-horticulture/>

P005 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

The Case of the Golden Idol

A Statue With No Respect for the Seating Chart

Edition considered: PC 2022 game with current Redux edition; not The Rise of the Golden Idol

The Golden Idol file arrived beside my gold stamp, and for a moment I enjoyed the resemblance. Then Shawna read the part about strange deaths. I moved the stamp farther away. Tank moved his chair farther away from both. Nobody appreciated my explanation that mine was merely expensive, not cursed.

I staged a practice scene using three paper figures and a fallen biscuit. Mercedes was asked to determine the motive. 'You wanted everyone looking at your statue.' 'The biscuit could have been politically significant.' She assigned it to the snack column. The clarity of her reasoning was becoming a professional problem.

A frozen scene was an inviting proposition: look again, compare the objects, reconsider who did what. It did not promise that the deduction would be easy. Shawna made that distinction before I could declare myself a genius for identifying the biscuit. Then Tank ate the murder weapon and our reconstruction acquired a second suspect.

The actual attraction

Static scenes of suspicious deaths become a larger conspiracy as names, objects, and motives connect. The reward is constructing an explanation that fits the evidence, with visual detail and social relationships doing much of the storytelling.

The catch worth knowing

Later cases add many names, roles, and possible words. Murder imagery is deliberate, and the grotesque art may not be welcoming. This card concerns the original game with its current Redux edition, not Rise. Check exact word-placement, text size, and hint controls rather than assuming every release behaves identically.

An opening invitation

Study the first scene and identify the people before attempting its full explanation. Try moving one word into a deduction slot, then inspect the hint interface if curiosity has turned into bookkeeping.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Suitable for an evening of suspicious objects, provided my gold stamp is kept outside the evidence room and preferably outside the building.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher describes freely investigated freeze-frame scenes; current-edition announcements establish Redux. Drag/hold behavior and full completion were not playtested.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1677770/>

Source 2: <https://steamcommunity.com/app/1677770/allnews/>

P006 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Syberia

The Business Trip That Refused to End at Lunch

Edition considered: 2002 PC original; not Syberia Remastered

Kate Walker travels to arrange a factory sale. I understood immediately: arrive, sign something, discover a machine with a personality, and accidentally become responsible for an entire journey. Tank said I had managed the same result buying a table. I told him my transaction had international significance. He held up the assembly instructions in six languages.

Syberia's automata appealed to my standards of office equipment. A machine should have dignity. It should also perform a recognizable task, a requirement our printer had been evading with artistic confidence. Shawna pointed out that Kate's journey mattered because her priorities changed, not because she bought a more impressive machine.

I prepared an itinerary titled QUICK STOP. Mercedes asked why it contained a train, an inventor, and half a continent. 'Flexibility.' She crossed out quick. We kept the journey and lost the sales pitch. That seemed closer to the game's promise, and considerably kinder to anyone reading my travel arrangements.

The actual attraction

The original Syberia follows a lawyer into an unusual European world of mechanical wonders and unfinished lives. Kate's changing sense of what matters gives the travel emotional momentum beyond collecting the next useful object.

The catch worth knowing

This is the 2002 PC original, not the remaster. Click movement removes a separate look control, but fixed camera cuts, small hotspots, dialogue topics, inventory, and repeated travel can still frustrate. The publisher walkthrough's late sections use ordinary interactions; that is not an exhaustive no-timer guarantee.

An opening invitation

Explore the opening hotel, speak with one person, and test the inventory and save route. Let one useful object establish whether the older interface is inviting before committing to a long journey.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Recommended when a peculiar train sounds more appealing than a realistic business meeting, which is a demanding but reasonable standard for an evening.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected original-game publisher description and seven-page official walkthrough, including late sequences. Original PC control scope only; no full playtest.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/46500/>

Source 2: <https://support.microids.com/fr/support/solutions/articles/23000009217-solutions-syberia-1-et-2>

P007 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Unavowed

My Companions Demand a Better Selection Screen

Edition considered: PC release

Unavowed offers companions with different talents. I announced that the Bureau already possessed the ideal team. Shawna could distinguish a fact from my enthusiasm, Rosa could feed people without founding an empire, Mercedes could end a foolish speech with one eyebrow, and Tank could carry the empire to the recycling bin. My own talent was leadership. Nobody wrote that down.

I tried selecting the day's party by arranging their photographs on the desk. Mercedes picked hers up. 'Ask.' 'This is a strategic interface.' 'Ask strategically.' So I asked who wanted to investigate a hidden supernatural New York. The conversation improved once the photographs stopped pretending to make decisions.

What caught me was the possibility of learning about people through the problems they solve together. Then Shawna read the content warning and the companion-ability demands. We placed both beside the promise. A rich ensemble could be worth the work, but even my department could not turn darkness into a light snack by changing the folder color.

The actual attraction

An urban-fantasy investigation puts companions, their histories, and their abilities at the center of puzzle solving. Origins and branching situations give the ensemble room to react differently, making the people a reason to explore the next case.

The catch worth knowing

Inventory plus companion abilities creates more to remember than a simple conversation game. Violence, possession, death, and strong language are substantial. Ordinary PC interaction is pointer-based, but urgent scenes and every branch's timing or holding demands have not been fully audited.

An opening invitation

Choose an origin because it sounds interesting, meet the opening companions, and try one interaction. Verify text waiting and pause on the actual edition before relying on the adventure's slower ordinary rhythm.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Granted an ensemble permit because four interesting companions can justify a longer story; they cannot justify my attempt to assign friendship through office photographs.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary publisher premise and companion features inspected. PC interaction and content detail supported by review; zero timed inputs across branches remains unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/336140/>

Source 2: <https://gamecritics.com/gc-staff/unavowed-review/>

P008 / CONDITIONAL / text input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

Her Story

The Search Term Was Not My Name

Edition considered: PC release

Her Story places an interview archive in front of the player. I entered my own name into our practice database, expecting relevance to recognize me. It returned a receipt for seventeen brass drawer handles. Tank leaned over. 'Strong opening. Motive established.' I suggested a more glamorous search term. Shawna suggested reading the result.

The game's unusual invitation was to notice a word, search it, and let another fragment change the question. Mercedes liked that the story did not need me to march a little man through a hallway before listening to a woman speak. I objected to the little man characterization. She clarified that she meant me.

I began creating a wall of theories. Rosa removed three arrows that all pointed to my photograph. We kept one question on a card instead. A story assembled from fragments could be compelling; it could also become a pile of names. The Bureau had produced enough piles to respect the distinction.

The actual attraction

A live-action police interview mystery lets a noticed word become the next direction of exploration. Performance, contradiction, and interpretation supply the interest; there is no avatar or separate look camera between the player and the testimony.

The catch worth knowing

Typing, names, nonlinear clips, and remembering what a phrase referred to can be demanding. Convenient video pausing is unverified: player reports describe holding the slider to freeze a clip. Do not assume search-at-your-own-pace means hands-free pause during playback. Crime and relationship material is mature.

An opening invitation

On desktop, watch one returned clip, test how it stops or replays, and follow one promising word. Keep a short question nearby only if it helps preserve the thread.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Accepted because the next useful clue may be a word rather than a key, and because the archive is under no obligation to admire my drawer handles.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary publisher describes search/watch loop. Pause limitation is dated secondary user evidence, not verified current behavior; Telling Lies controls must not be substituted.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/368370/>

Source 2: <https://steamcommunity.com/app/368370/discussions/0/530645446312998268/>

P009 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

The Excavation of Hob's Barrow

A Very Poor Location for the Staff Picnic

Edition considered: PC release

I saw an atmospheric Yorkshire village and proposed a Bureau retreat. Rosa asked what the trip involved. 'History. Countryside. A burial mound.' She stopped packing the picnic basket. Tank asked whether the mound had parking. Mercedes asked whether it had a reason to stay buried. Shawna read the words folk horror aloud until my brochure began to look dishonest.

The Excavation of Hob's Barrow interested me precisely because its landscape and people withheld an easy answer. Thomasina arrives to investigate, and the invitation does not become less peculiar when she reaches it. I respected a story with the confidence to make a village feel like an unresolved question.

I changed the excursion form from relaxing getaway to dark story for those who want one. Rosa put the basket away. 'Better.' Tank kept one sandwich for emergency research. We could appreciate atmosphere without pretending dread was a hospitality feature. My proposed lantern budget remained excellent, but irrelevant.

The actual attraction

Victorian folk horror gives its investigation a strong sense of place: moors, suspicious villagers, an antiquarian, and a burial mound. For someone who enjoys unease, the slow accumulation of wrongness may be as engaging as solving the inventory puzzles.

The catch worth knowing

Bleak horror, violence, and abrupt audiovisual moments can create pressure without a reflex timer. PC descriptions include inventory dragging. A Switch accessibility assessment reports low pressure and optional holds, but that does not prove hold-free PC play. Later puzzle chains still require remembering information.

An opening invitation

Try the opening village and one conversation. Test an inventory action and text advance on the exact edition; leave if the atmosphere itself is unpleasant, even if the controls behave perfectly.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Issued a lantern rather than a cozy stamp: suitable only when suspicious soil sounds like an invitation instead of a reason to choose another room.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher horror premise inspected. Switch low-pressure panel and PC drag description are secondary and edition-specific; no blanket control guarantee.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1182310/>

Source 2: <https://www.nintendolife.com/reviews/switch-eshop/the-excavation-of-hobs-barrow>

Source 3: https://as.com/meristation/2022/09/28/analysis/1664375021_208084.html

P010 / CONDITIONAL / mixed input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

Pentiment

The Meeting That Consumed Tuesday

Edition considered: PC release

Pentiment made me nostalgic for a time when an important man could spend an afternoon discussing art and call it work. Shawna said I had done that yesterday while choosing the border on my nameplate. 'Historical continuity,' I explained. She opened the receipt and found the extra charge for historical continuity.

The game's community changes through relationships and decisions, and investigating one lead can mean leaving another behind. I attempted to solve this by scheduling every conversation simultaneously. Tank attended a meeting with three empty chairs and a bowl of nuts. He reported unanimous agreement that the bowl should be larger.

There was no need to race a button press to find this sort of choice weighty. Mercedes crossed out my phrase perfectly relaxing. She replaced it with interesting if consequential decisions appeal. I protested that this was less marketable. 'Good,' she said. 'Now it tells somebody something.' The nameplate border survived, but the sales pitch did not.

The actual attraction

A richly drawn historical community makes art, class, faith, and personal loyalties part of the investigation. People and consequences unfold over years, offering conversation and interpretation rather than a constant demand for quick physical reactions.

The catch worth knowing

Developer accessibility notes state there are no timed inputs or QTEs. Investigation time still advances through chosen activities, which creates decision pressure. Reading is extensive, movement may require holding, and names and relationships accumulate. Narration support differs by platform; do not assume every line is spoken.

An opening invitation

Try walking and one early conversation with readable text settings. Notice whether choosing a lead feels intriguing or burdensome before promising yourself an entire investigation or an optimal outcome.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Registered for readers who enjoy a community with arguments worth hearing, subject to the finding that my calendar cannot make two afternoons out of one.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected developer accessibility notes and first-hand interview on activity-based investigation time. Turn pacing differs from decision pressure; actual movement setup untested.

Source 1: <https://pentiment.obsidian.net/>

Source 2: <https://www.mmorpg.com/interviews/the-rpg-files-building-obsidians-pentiment-interview-with-game-director-josh-sawyer-2000126821>

The Evidence Has Been Eating the Evidence

By midday, the Bureau had solved three minor administrative mysteries and created a fourth. The missing pencils were behind my ear, the missing coffee was in Tank, and the printer's complaint about paper size was apparently a complaint about paper size. I had assumed a deeper motive. The fourth mystery concerned a packet labeled URGENT. Inside were six perfectly ordinary crackers and a note from Rosa: not everything in a red envelope is an emergency.

I convened a hearing. 'The department has been misled.' 'By color?' Mercedes asked. 'By presentation.' Shawna turned the packet over. 'It also says crackers.' 'Fine print.' 'It's larger than urgent.' Tank ate one while the evidence was being discussed. I asked him to preserve the chain of custody. He held out the remaining packet. 'Chain starts here. Ends here.' He pointed to his mouth. I entered his explanation into the record under deeply unhelpful and completely accurate.

We had reached the portion of the work where a phrase like point-and-click began trying to do too many jobs. It told us something about a game's ordinary interaction. It did not tell us whether an item had to be dragged, whether dialogue waited, whether a late confrontation demanded a quick response, or whether the inventory contained three things or half a hardware store. Shawna put separate tabs on those questions. I had bought tabs in twelve colors. For the first time all day, a purchase of mine became useful without modification.

The printer produced an extra copy of the same page. I held it up. 'Independent corroboration.' 'Same printer,' said Mercedes. 'Same page,' said Rosa. 'Same expensive idiot,' said Tank, very quietly, because he still wanted access to the snack cabinet. We did not count duplicated claims as fresh evidence. We also did not turn an absent warning into a promise. Some cards had a clear statement from the publisher; some had a specific review; some still needed a check on the actual edition. A blank space stayed a blank space.

Then the gold stamp disappeared. For nine minutes I pursued a theory involving international rivals, a forged signature, and the service elevator. Shawna found it beside the kettle, holding down a curling recipe card. 'I needed something heavy.' 'That seal represents my judgment.' 'Then it's found appropriate work.' She left it there. I was permitted to keep the handle, provided I did not call it an official accessibility certification. Tank wrote KETTLE DIVISION on a fresh label and applied it to my nameplate.

We returned to the cases with less stationery and better questions. Which world looked worth entering? What would your hands actually do? What might pile up in memory? Did a game let the player wait, or did we merely hope it did? There was no humiliation in deciding against a promising story because its interface was unpleasant. The Bureau's job was to offer possibilities. The visitor's job, if any, was to enjoy the evening. Mine was apparently to stop standing in front of the tea bags.

P011 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Old Skies

Yesterday Is Outside the Refund Window

Edition considered: PC release

I wanted a time-travel department for one specific purpose: canceling the table order before Shawna saw it. Tank said we could also retrieve the pastry he dropped that morning. Mercedes proposed returning to the exact second before I founded the department. I began to suspect our historical priorities were incompatible.

Old Skies assigns Fia Quinn the job of supervising paying travelers through the past. This sounded alarmingly like customer service with consequences larger than a bad review. I composed a waiver. Shawna read the first line, which excused me from responsibility for the nineteenth century, and put it in the shredder.

The attraction was not simply visiting different dates. It was encountering people with reasons to go back, then dealing with what those reasons meant. I had been thinking about furniture; the game had unfinished lives in mind. Tank quietly removed his pastry request, although he asked whether crumbs counted as a historical record.

The actual attraction

A time agent's work provides seven historical settings and travelers with different motives. Temporal puzzles and a voiced ensemble connect the speculative premise to questions about regret, curiosity, and the consequences of changing what already happened.

The catch worth knowing

The publisher explicitly says the player can die and try again. That is a meaningful failure-state warning, not proof of harmless pacing. Temporal cause and effect can increase memory demands, and later timing, dragging, and dialogue advance need an edition-specific check. Some historical settings carry serious emotional weight.

An opening invitation

Meet Fia and inspect the first assignment before promising a complete excursion. Test ordinary object interaction and the pause/save route; treat any stressful sequence as a reason to reconsider, not an examination to pass.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Authorized for curiosity about yesterday, with a strict prohibition on using the past to conceal my perfectly traceable furniture expenditure.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher description: time-agent premise, historical eras, temporal puzzles, and retryable death. No declared absence of timed sequences established.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1346360/>

P012 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Primordia

The Printer Discovers Religion

Edition considered: PC release

Primordia concerns robots living among the remains of humanity. I explained this premise to our printer, hoping it would develop perspective. It requested magenta. Tank said perhaps that was its sacred text. I opened the maintenance panel and found enough paper dust to establish a small archaeological site.

Horatio and Crispin's search for a stolen power core struck me as a sensible beginning for a much larger question. Who made this world? What did its makers leave behind? Why does every office possess a cable that fits nothing? Shawna told me the last question was ours, not the game's, and handed me another useless cable.

I liked the contrast between a solitary, principled machine and a companion willing to answer back. Mercedes said we already had that dynamic, except I was neither solitary nor a machine and my principles came with accessories. The printer hummed. For the first time I thought it might be laughing at the correct person.

The actual attraction

A robot partnership explores a post-human landscape and a city whose history changes the meaning of the initial theft. Mechanical decay, belief, independence, and companion banter make its world distinctive rather than merely another collection of locked doors.

The catch worth knowing

Environmental and inventory puzzles still ask for connections and returning to details. Optional puzzles exist, but optional extras do not make the main path effortless. The inspected storefront does not certify zero timers, no holds, or a particular text-wait setting; those remain checks, not benefits to assume.

An opening invitation

Spend an opening scene with Horatio and Crispin. Try examining one object and following one concrete problem, then decide whether the world's mood and puzzle language invite another visit.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Entered because a philosophical robot may provide better company than an actual office printer, despite both having strong opinions about power supplies.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected exact-game publisher description for robots, stolen core, Metropol and optional puzzles. Control and complete-path timing guarantees were not found in that record.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/227000/>

P013 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Strangeland

The Carnival Fails Its Hospitality Inspection

Edition considered: PC release

I suggested a carnival theme for the Bureau's open evening. Rosa asked what attractions I had in mind. I showed her Strangeland: a nightmare park, unsettling inhabitants, and a mystery connected to a woman's repeated death. She returned my proposed welcome banner face down. 'You need to say horror before you say outing.'

The game interested Mercedes because its strange images had something to mean, not simply something to startle. I attempted a profound interpretation of our broken copier. She unplugged it. 'Some metaphors are just broken equipment.' Tank had already named the snack cabinet the Furnace of Endless Want. We allowed that one to stand.

There could be pleasure in deciphering this disturbing world, provided disturbing was what somebody actually wanted. We replaced the carnival invitation with a clear description. No smiley sticker made it gentler. I kept one balloon for myself. It deflated during my explanation of symbolism, which seemed unnecessarily editorial.

The actual attraction

A surreal carnival turns identity, grief, and interpretation into an adventure's setting and puzzles. The publisher describes different solutions and meanings, a voiced cast, and an optional in-character hint system, giving the strange inhabitants more purpose than decoration.

The catch worth knowing

Suicide imagery, repeated death, grotesque bodies, and horror are central. Alternative puzzle solutions do not establish a fully reaction-free path; the publisher itself contrasts a shooting approach with another solution. Inventory reasoning and symbolic interpretation can also be substantial. Verify actual interaction before relying on a particular route.

An opening invitation

Read the premise and look at the opening atmosphere before beginning an investigation. If that is appealing, try one conversation and locate the optional hint system; no need to demonstrate tolerance for distressing imagery.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A permit for the deliberately uncanny, withdrawn immediately if the desired carnival contains ordinary popcorn and no existential furnace.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher description explicitly covers nightmare imagery, multiple solutions and hints. No universal timing or hold exemption inferred from those alternatives.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1369520/>

P014 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Shardlight

The Stamp Cannot Distribute Hope

Edition considered: PC release

Shardlight's city is ruled by people controlling scarce resources. I immediately hid the Bureau's snack ledger. Rosa found it anyway. 'This says executive biscuits.' 'A quality distinction.' 'It says everyone else may apply.' Tank had filled out three applications under different names, all with the same mustard fingerprint.

Amy Wellard's search for a cure was a different scale of story entirely: a person trying to act inside an unjust system rather than waiting for it to become kind. I took the gold stamp off the table. Some premises do not need management jokes at the center of their explanation. The joke could stay where it belonged, on my ridiculous ledger.

Mercedes opened the cupboard and redistributed the biscuits without commissioning a reform paper. Shawna wrote down the game's bleakness beside its appeal. A determined heroine and a troubled world might be engrossing, but nobody had asked us to disguise disease and deprivation as a pleasant afternoon in a village.

The actual attraction

Amy's investigation gives an oppressive post-apocalyptic world a personal point of entry. The premise puts inequality, loyalty, and the search for a cure into the story, offering a protagonist with a concrete reason to keep asking difficult questions.

The catch worth knowing

Disease, hunger, death, and coercive government are explicit parts of the setting. They can make the experience emotionally heavy even during quiet interaction. Adventure puzzles bring inventory and clue demands. The source inspected here does not establish all-path timing, holding, or dialogue-wait behavior; those require a specific check.

An opening invitation

Try the opening conversation and one stated task only if the setting appeals. Test an inventory interaction and find save/quit before taking on the wider investigation or its darker consequences.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Chosen for a heroine willing to challenge the people controlling the cupboard; the Bureau's executive biscuit classification has consequently been abolished.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact publisher premise inspected, including deprivation and vaccine lottery. Pointer-adventure classification is editorial; no complete-path control verification claimed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/336130/>

P015 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Technobabylon

Central Has Denied My Password Request

Edition considered: PC release

Technobabylon's future includes an omnipresent city AI. I offered our printer the position on a temporary basis. It went offline. Mercedes said this was the clearest policy decision the Bureau had received all morning. Tank asked whether the AI could locate his headphones. They were around his neck; he requested that this remain classified.

The game's three perspectives interested me more than the impressive machinery. People inside the same system could have sharply different loyalties, vulnerabilities, and reasons for breaking its rules. Shawna liked that distinction. I tried adding it to the department charter. The charter immediately exceeded the stapler's capacity.

We put the cyberpunk file beside the words mature themes, not under the category shiny future. I had once assumed a good interface could solve any institutional problem. Then I remembered the lunch-order spreadsheet I built with seventeen required fields. Rosa brought me a sandwich and refused to call it a workflow improvement.

The actual attraction

Interwoven perspectives bring a cyberpunk city's systems down to individual choices and loyalties. A police conspiracy, virtual experience, and complicated personal stakes can supply a rich story for someone who enjoys gradually discovering how a speculative society works.

The catch worth knowing

Three protagonists, unfamiliar terms, inventory solutions, and layered motives increase the amount to track. The publisher warns of mature themes and violence. Point-and-click presentation does not establish that every later confrontation waits indefinitely, nor that every interaction avoids holds; the inspected source leaves those questions open.

An opening invitation

Follow one opening character and one immediate objective. Check text advance, ordinary interaction, and saving before deciding whether learning this future feels interesting rather than like another system to administer.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Filed for readers who want to question a powerful computer without spending the entire evening explaining to my printer that it is already connected.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher account of three protagonists, Central, Trance, conspiracy and mature content. Exact late-game input demands remain unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/307580/>

P016 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Blackwell Unbound

The Department Purchases a Saxophone Alibi

Edition considered: PC release

Blackwell Unbound begins its invitation with 1973 New York and an ethereal saxophone. I decided the Bureau required a more atmospheric entrance. Tank found a recording on his phone. Unfortunately an advertisement for patio furniture interrupted the haunting. The room became melancholy about discounted cushions.

Lauren Blackwell and Joey investigate connections ordinary people have missed. I liked a mystery built from a sound in one place and suspicious trouble elsewhere. Shawna asked whether our new saxophone budget connected to my recent interest in wearing a long coat indoors. I said the evidence was circumstantial. Mercedes said the coat still had the tag on it.

We distinguished this earlier-set story from Rosa's first adventure instead of pretending a sequel number explained everything. Familiarity could help, but it was not an admission requirement set by me. Rosa switched off the advert. The quiet that followed was excellent, and unlike the coat, it had cost us nothing.

The actual attraction

An earlier Blackwell investigation changes the central human partner while retaining Joey's sardonic presence. Period New York, a ghostly musician, and apparently separate incidents provide a contained supernatural mystery with a different emotional texture from Legacy.

The catch worth knowing

Clues, names, dialogue topics, and switching attention between the living and the dead can still require tracking. This title's publisher record does not certify the same manual-speech patch behavior as another Blackwell game. Do not transfer Legacy's review-based timing assurance or Ctrl+P setup without checking this edition.

An opening invitation

Meet Lauren and Joey, listen to the first lead, and inspect the actual text and interaction settings. Continue because their relationship interests you, not because a series order has become another obligation.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Issued a period-appropriate file for anyone tempted by a supernatural saxophone, with the Bureau's patio-furniture advertisement removed from the atmosphere.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher description establishes Lauren, Joey, 1973 and connected incidents. Input settings and no-timer claims are not inherited from other series entries.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/80340/>

P017 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Blackwell Convergence

The Empty Office Has a Better Lease Than We Do

Edition considered: PC release

Blackwell Convergence offers an empty uptown office, a troubled film, an artist, and an investor. I liked the empty office best until Shawna reminded me that it was evidence, not available workspace. I had already measured where the table might go. Tank asked whether a haunting reduced the deposit.

A story drawing separate city lives together suited the Bureau's finest habit: suspecting that everything was connected. Mercedes pointed out that our missing labels and our jammed printer were connected because I had fed the labels into the wrong tray. Not every conspiracy required a corkboard. Some required reading the arrow on a box.

Still, there was pleasure in seeing a familiar partnership follow a new set of threads. We placed the game beside its predecessors without claiming that returning characters eliminated every burden. I crossed out my property inquiry. Shawna kept the measuring tape, correctly anticipating that I would mistake another mysterious room for a branch office.

The actual attraction

Rosa and Joey return to a city mystery whose apparently separate people and locations conceal a larger connection. Familiar characters can make another investigation attractive after an earlier entry, while the art, film, and finance setting gives it a specific flavor.

The catch worth knowing

This is a later series entry, so character history and supernatural rules add context to the clues. Inventory and conversational deductions remain work. The inspected publisher description establishes the premise, not a guarantee about timed scenes, held inputs, or current dialogue controls on every version.

An opening invitation

If the partnership already appeals, investigate one opening location and one lead. Check text waiting and item use on this installation rather than relying on remembered settings from a different Blackwell title.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Accepted for the pleasure of discovering why strangers share a secret, with an explicit ban on converting an unoccupied crime scene into my executive suite.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher premise inspected for connected film, office, artist and investor story. Later-series burden is editorial judgment; control guarantees remain unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/80350/>

P018 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Blackwell Deception

The Fortune Teller Predicts a Rejected Expense Claim

Edition considered: PC release

I set up a neon sign promising wealth, happiness, and a correctly sorted game shelf. Mercedes asked which promise I could substantiate. I demonstrated the sign's excellent electrical workmanship. She unplugged it. The future became darker but more accurate.

Blackwell Deception concerns people exploiting hope, and the spirits left behind when their victims die. That made the distinction between an entertaining mystery and an actual promise particularly useful. Shawna took my APPROVED stamp away from the recommendation column. 'Nobody gets guaranteed happiness from stationery.' Tank asked whether the guarantee included the neon sign's return policy.

Rosa and Joey's investigation could still be inviting: clubs, apartments, a yacht, and secrets with personal consequences. I pictured myself arriving discreetly at the yacht. Everyone pictured the opposite. We left the game to its detectives and the sign to its box. On the box, Tank wrote FUTURE PENDING REFUND in very clear letters.

The actual attraction

A mystery about fraudulent psychics lets an established supernatural partnership investigate both exploitation and personal secrets. Contrasting city settings and Joey's buried history may reward someone already curious about these characters rather than only the next puzzle solution.

The catch worth knowing

Death and manipulation of vulnerable hopes are central themes. Existing series relationships, dialogue, and clue connections can accumulate. The publisher premise does not establish an all-path absence of timed inputs or holds. Current text advance and inventory behavior should be checked independently of earlier Blackwell editions.

An opening invitation

Try one conversation and one lead if Rosa and Joey are welcome company. Notice the tone as well as the controls; interest in supernatural mysteries does not require enjoying every kind of darker subject.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Granted investigation rights because a story can question false promises while offering good company; my neon happiness guarantee has been removed from service.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected exact-game publisher description of psychic fraud and Joey's secrets. No unsupported transfer of input or timing features from another Blackwell game.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/80360/>

P019 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Blackwell Epiphany

The Blizzard Is Not a Seasonal Decoration

Edition considered: PC release

I requested snow for the Bureau's winter mystery display. The supplier asked how much. 'Enough to suggest depth.' Tank read Blackwell Epiphany's premise and said we should start by suggesting a coat. Shawna pointed to the threat against the dead themselves. I quietly removed the phrase festive chills from the welcome card.

A series reaching a grave question about its own supernatural world could be powerful precisely because the characters had become familiar. Mercedes said that was different from requiring everyone to begin with the finale. I had been about to announce a shortcut through four games. Apparently emotional context could not be expedited by courier.

We placed the file near the earlier investigations, with room for someone to choose the beginning instead. Tank put the artificial snow back in its carton. One handful remained on my chair. When I sat down, a glittering cloud rose around the director, providing all the seasonal foolishness the room actually needed.

The actual attraction

The final Blackwell story raises the stakes around Rosa, Joey, and the nature of the spirits they help. For someone already attached to the partnership, the larger mystery offers emotional continuity and the possibility of a meaningful series conclusion.

The catch worth knowing

Destruction of souls, death, and a bleak winter atmosphere make this a darker choice. It is a later entry with accumulated character history, not necessarily the best introduction. The publisher's story description does not verify every timed, held-input, or text-advance behavior; inspect this edition directly.

An opening invitation

Consider whether earlier Blackwell stories sound more inviting before opening the finale. If continuing an enjoyed series, try the opening investigation and verify dialogue waiting and saving without committing to finishing its darker arc.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Reserved for an existing attachment to these two investigators, not for my theory that putting snow on a folder makes tragedy suitable for a holiday party.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher description of the central threat. Series-position recommendation is editorial; no complete-path control or emotional-fit guarantee.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/236930/>

P020 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

The Shivah: Kosher Edition

The Donation Arrives With a Question Mark

Edition considered: PC Kosher Edition

An unexpected payment arrived at the Bureau, and I immediately planned a second nameplate. Shawna checked the envelope. It was a refund for a canceled nameplate. Tank said the department had finally discovered a renewable source of disappointment.

The Shivah begins with a financially troubled rabbi receiving money from a dead former congregant and being unable to simply take the windfall at face value. The interesting part was conscience making an apparently convenient answer insufficient. I understood that in principle. In practice, I had already selected the second nameplate's lettering.

Mercedes asked what I would do if the money carried a difficult history. 'Investigate.' 'Before buying the sign?' I took a moment to demonstrate thoughtfulness. Rosa set a plain handwritten label on my desk. It said AIDEN, in ordinary ink, and performed the entire job. We gave the fictional rabbi his moral question and left my stationery problem at an appropriately smaller scale.

The actual attraction

A short-form mystery places conscience, faith, and doubt inside a specific New York community. Russell Stone's reason to investigate is personal and ethical, giving the conversations an appeal beyond collecting evidence for an abstract case.

The catch worth knowing

This card specifies the Kosher Edition, whose publisher lists revised presentation, voiced dialogue, multiple endings, and a distinctive conversation/combat system. That last feature requires checking rather than assuming all point-and-click interaction is relaxed. Death, cynicism, and moral decisions also give it a serious tone.

An opening invitation

Meet Rabbi Stone and hear the premise. Preview how a conversation choice works and how to save or leave; do not use the early calm as proof that the later confrontation has no timing demands.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Accepted when an inconvenient moral question sounds more interesting than an uncomplicated windfall; the Bureau will investigate its refund before ordering anything engraved.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher's explicitly titled Kosher Edition page, including conversation/combat and endings. Timing and holds not verified; unrelated or unresolved store matches excluded.

Source 1: <https://wadjeteyegames.com/games/the-shivah/>

P021 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Resonance

Four Witnesses, One Deeply Suspicious Whiteboard

Edition considered: PC release

I announced that our investigation now required four simultaneous versions of me. Shawna asked whether one reliable version might be a cheaper pilot. I explained that Resonance followed four people whose lives converged around dangerous scientific work. Clearly, a man with my range should cover at least three of them. Tank put four mugs on the desk and watched me lose track of which one contained tea.

The whiteboard was divided into LONG-TERM MEMORY, SHORT-TERM MEMORY, and THINGS AIDEN SAID WITH CONFIDENCE. Mercedes drew a thick border around the last section. 'Separate evidentiary standard.' I connected the tea mugs with red string, which made the drinking arrangements considerably worse without advancing particle physics.

When Rosa asked what the actual appeal was, I said secrets, intersecting lives, and the pleasure of noticing connections. 'Good,' she said. 'Leave that on the board.' The rest came down, including the string attached to my watch.

The actual attraction

Four playable characters approach a science-fiction conspiracy from different lives and loyalties. The unusual memory system lets remembered subjects become conversation material, giving investigation more texture than simply collecting objects and exhausting a fixed list of questions.

The catch worth knowing

Character switching, separate knowledge, inventory and two kinds of stored memory create substantial bookkeeping. The developer's dramatic race-against-the-clock wording does not establish which passages use actual timers. Required late action and held-input demands remain unverified; this is a conditional mystery, not a no-rush certification.

An opening invitation

Explore one character's first available conversation and inspect how a remembered subject becomes a question. Keep a short note with that character's name and immediate objective before considering a second viewpoint.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admit when connecting four suspicious lives sounds enjoyable; decline if the Bureau's four-mug incident already resembles an unpaid administrative position.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Developer page supports four playable characters and the long-/short-term memory system. It does not verify a wholly untimed path. This is Wadjet Eye's adventure, not another product with Resonance in its name.

Source 1: <https://wadjeteyegames.com/games/resonance/>

P022 / DETOUR / mixed input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

Gemini Rue

The Raincoat Does Not Remove the Gunfight

Edition considered: PC release

I wore a raincoat into the Bureau to establish noir credibility. The ceiling was dry. Tank supplied a small watering can and asked whether authenticity should include the paperwork. Gemini Rue looked exactly like the sort of rain-soaked, compromised future in which I could deliver an excellent monologue beside a broken neon sign.

Mercedes read the file. 'There's combat.' I continued gazing mournfully through the window. 'A troubled man confronts his past.' 'And combat.' I adjusted the collar. 'Two lives, fractured identity, institutional secrets.' She placed the word COMBAT directly over the portrait I had clipped to the dossier.

Shawna explained that atmosphere and input were separate questions. That was inconveniently correct. I surrendered the raincoat and kept the recommendation in the detour drawer, where an interesting story could remain interesting without pretending its gunfights were merely enthusiastic conversations. Tank watered the office plant instead. It immediately looked more qualified for detective work.

The actual attraction

Azriel's search on a bleak colony world intertwines with an amnesiac captive's story. The attraction is adult science-fiction noir: damaged identities, oppressive institutions, rain, and uncertainty about how two apparently separate lives connect.

The catch worth knowing

This adventure includes required combat, so ordinary point-and-click investigation does not describe the complete experience. The PC interface also uses contextual actions. A publisher announcement discusses redesigned combat for a mobile port; that port's accommodations must not be assumed present on PC. A no-rush route is not established.

An opening invitation

If the atmosphere appeals, inspect an early investigation scene while someone checks the PC combat requirements separately. Do not treat a comfortable conversation as evidence that the later action will suit.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Keep for a deliberate noir detour or shared viewing, with the gunfight warning attached more firmly than my decorative detective badge ever was.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

PC store supports the dual-character premise; the developer's mobile announcement explicitly confirms a combat system. Mobile redesign claims are not transferred to the PC edition. Complete PC control/timing accommodations are unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/80310/>

Source 2: <https://wadjeteyegames.com/2013/04/11/gemini-rue-now-on-the-app-store/>

P023 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Emerald City Confidential

The Emerald City Has Retained Counsel

Edition considered: PC release

The moment I heard Oz had a private investigator, I prepared my testimony. Mercedes asked what crime I was confessing to. 'None. I am a valuable witness to my own importance.' She opened a fresh notebook under the heading MOTIVE. Emerald City Confidential offered familiar storybook figures wearing the moral weather of a detective film, which struck me as an overdue improvement to civic tourism.

Tank arrived with a green desk lamp and a receipt charging it to Magical Infrastructure. I approved the expense until Shawna pointed out that this meant our missing stapler now qualified as a metropolitan corruption case. The lamp cast a sinister glow over its perfectly ordinary position beside my elbow.

Rosa suggested we let Petra, the actual detective, conduct her own inquiry. I agreed, provided the city recognized my consulting status. Mercedes wrote CONSULTING STATUS: UNRECOGNIZED. For a supposedly enchanted place, Oz had acquired excellent standards.

The actual attraction

Petra investigates an Oz recast as a noir city, meeting altered versions of recognizable figures. The pleasure lies in the friction between childhood storybook associations and a mystery full of suspects, witnesses and complicated motives.

The catch worth knowing

Recognizable characters do not make the investigation childish or mechanically effortless. Expect dialogue, clues and puzzle connections across locations. The inspected publisher material establishes the mystery structure but does not settle every timed sequence, drag gesture or later input requirement. Treat those as checks, not absent features.

An opening invitation

Meet Petra and follow one early conversation far enough to decide whether the reimagined Oz feels intriguing. Inspect one clue deliberately before opening a larger chain of objectives or consulting a walkthrough.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Approve if a fairy-tale city hiring a tired detective is your kind of absurdity; the green lamp confers atmosphere, no professional qualifications and absolutely no jurisdiction over snacks.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher descriptions support Petra, the Oz reinterpretation, voiced characters and investigation across five chapters. No blanket no-timer or hold-free claim is established.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/37260/>

Source 2: <https://wadjeteyegames.com/games/emerald-city-confidential/>

P024 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

The Mermaid Mask

Submarine Reservations for a Man Who Cannot Pack Light

Edition considered: PC release; current release status verify

I booked the Bureau an imaginary submarine excursion because a murder aboard a peculiar vessel deserved maritime expertise. Tank looked at the six trunks I had assembled. 'Which one contains the expertise?' I pointed to the smallest. It contained cufflinks, a compass-shaped biscuit and a photograph of me beside a boat that had never left its restaurant.

Grimoire and Sally were investigating the Mortuga. I proposed joining as Chief Surface Consultant. Shawna explained that a locked-room mystery did not improve when an extra man arrived carrying a portable lectern. Mercedes added that the submarine was already suspicious enough without my luggage manifest.

We inspected the game instead. Strange crew, detailed objects, an impossible death: at last, a vessel with something better to offer than my nautical speech. Rosa unpacked the biscuit. My compass was eaten before it could lead anybody astray, which counts as an unusually successful voyage.

The actual attraction

Grimoire and Sally investigate a captain's death aboard an eccentric submarine. Voiced suspects, an elaborate locked-room setup and objects to examine offer a richly theatrical detective outing, with the investigators' partnership anchoring the weirdness.

The catch worth knowing

The current PC listing declares play without timed input, mouse-only play and saving at any time. Those are developer declarations, not a personal control trial. Inspectable three-dimensional clues may still involve gestures worth testing; dialogue, case-file relationships and deductions retain a meaningful memory load.

An opening invitation

Enter an early conversation, inspect a clue, then test how its view changes and how the case file records it. Judge those operations before committing to solving the whole submarine's personnel problems.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Strongly consider for a strange, characterful mystery whose official pacing declaration is encouraging. Bring curiosity; leave the six-trunk consulting practice on the dock where it belongs.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact current Steam game and SFB site confirm release, premise and developer-declared Mouse Only, Playable without Timed Input and Save Anytime. Released July 16, 2026. Object-manipulation comfort is not independently verified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1696770/>

Source 2: <https://www.sfbgames.com/>

P025 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Broken Sword - Shadow of the Templars: Reforged

The Tourist Who Filed a Conspiracy Expense Claim

Edition considered: PC Reforged edition

Paris seemed an excellent place to expand the Bureau. I imagined a tasteful office above a cafe, my name on the glass, and an expense account capable of understanding pastries. George Stobbart's holiday apparently took a different direction. Shawna described the Templar mystery. I crossed out LEISURE and wrote RESEARCH in the same expensive pen.

Mercedes asked why every item on my itinerary was edible. 'Local intelligence.' Tank held up a croissant. 'Then this source is flaky.' I considered dismissing him until Rosa pointed out that his report was both accurate and already paid for.

Broken Sword's attraction was the journey: George and Nico, places with history, questions that grow beyond one incident. I tried to appoint myself Third Lead. Mercedes assigned me the more practical role of Person Who Remembers Where We Put the Mouse. It was demanding work, but for once the appointment addressed an actual vacancy.

The actual attraction

George Stobbart and journalist Nico Collard follow a Templar conspiracy through a classic travel adventure. Reforged presents the first Broken Sword in a modern visual edition, retaining the appeal of conversation, places, objects and a mystery expanding beyond an ordinary trip.

The catch worth knowing

Classic inventory logic and returning to locations can require notes or outside hints. The inspected Reforged page does not establish an entirely untimed, hold-free completion path. Verify troublesome set pieces in this exact edition before recommending it for a strict no-rush requirement; older versions are not interchangeable evidence.

An opening invitation

Try an early safe conversation and inspect a nearby object, watching whether the interface makes available actions clear. Stop after that small investigation and decide whether the travel-mystery tone earns further checking.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admit provisionally for people who enjoy a holiday acquiring historical complications. My pastry receipts remain excluded from the evidence because somebody has eaten the exhibits and the margins.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Revolution's page identifies the 2024 Reforged edition and supports premise and adventure structure. Full-path timing and held-input details remain unverified; no older-edition accommodation is assumed.

Source 1: https://revolution.co.uk/games_catalog/broken-sword-1/

P026 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Broken Sword 2 - the Smoking Mirror: Remastered

An Obsidian Artifact Versus My Gift-Shop Magnet

Edition considered: PC Remastered edition

An obsidian artifact can apparently begin a vast international mystery. I put our souvenir fridge magnet into an evidence bag and waited for the same professional momentum. Mercedes read its inscription: I WENT TO THE BEACH. 'The conspiracy is concealing very little.' I told her that obviousness was often the first layer.

Broken Sword's second case reunited George and Nico around a dangerous discovery. I reunited Tank and Rosa around the problem of my evidence bag being the last clean sandwich bag. Rosa resolved that conflict in favor of lunch. The magnet resumed its civilian employment holding up a shopping list.

Shawna reminded me that this was the Remastered second game, not a fresh copy of the first one's guarantees. I said the Bureau loved precision. She turned my dossier around. I had written BROKEN SPOON. In my defense, the kitchen had recently suffered an unrelated incident and deserved its own investigation.

The actual attraction

George and Nico return in a second globe-spanning mystery involving an artifact, criminal entanglements and a larger historical threat. The attraction is their continuing partnership and the traditional pleasure of turning an apparently isolated discovery into a much stranger story.

The catch worth knowing

The Remastered edition must be assessed on its own. Inventory puzzles, revisiting places and remembering what each person knows can become demanding. Its adventure label does not prove that every hazardous scene waits indefinitely; the inspected developer page leaves complete timing and hold requirements unresolved.

An opening invitation

Inspect the actual controls and one early interaction before investing in a long session. If the opening danger itself feels unwelcome, switch games rather than treating endurance as the price of seeing the later mystery.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

File beside the first adventure for readers who want more of this particular partnership, with its own control questions attached. Do not substitute the beach magnet for a second source.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Revolution identifies the second game's Remastered edition and artifact-led story. No edition-specific complete no-timer/no-hold route was verified.

Source 1: https://revolution.co.uk/games_catalog/broken-sword-2/

P027 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Broken Sword 5 - the Serpent's Curse

The Gallery Has Rejected My Self-Portrait

Edition considered: PC complete release

A stolen painting brought George and Nico back to work. I understood immediately. My own portrait had vanished from the Bureau reception area that morning. I assembled the staff, dimmed the lights and demanded to know who benefited from my disappearance. 'The reception area,' Mercedes said. Even Shawna looked away to hide a smile.

Tank produced the painting from behind a chair. He had moved it because its frame blocked the thermostat. I explained that art often challenged comfort. Rosa explained that visitors should not have to roast beneath my painted expression of modest achievement.

The Serpent's Curse offered a more substantial gallery crime than our heating dispute: murder, a missing work and a conspiracy. I restored the room to normal and wrote one excellent question at the top of the file. Why that painting? Mercedes nodded. 'See? You can investigate something without making it a referendum on your cheekbones.'

The actual attraction

The fifth Broken Sword begins with a Paris gallery robbery and murder, then follows George and Nico into a conspiracy. Fully voiced characters and classic point-and-click investigation make it an invitation to follow people, motives and a troublesome work of art.

The catch worth knowing

Expect inventory reasoning and an expanding cast. Revolution lists extra interface features under a separate Definitive Edition heading; this card does not assume that those features exist in the selected PC release. Required timing, holds and speech-advance behavior need checking in the installed edition.

An opening invitation

Follow the first available witness exchange and inspect a piece of gallery evidence. Notice whether dialogue pace and object selection feel comfortable before adding a second location or a page of speculative connections.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Recommend conditionally when a cultured theft turning into an uncultured conspiracy sounds appealing. Portraits of Bureau personnel are not acceptable substitutes for checking which edition is actually installed.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Developer page supports gallery theft/murder and classic point-and-click structure. Its Definitive Edition feature list is explicitly not transferred to the unspecified complete PC edition; full timing remains unverified.

Source 1: https://revolution.co.uk/games_catalog/broken-sword-5/

P028 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Beneath a Steel Sky

The City Computer Wants My Expense Password

Edition considered: 1994 PC original

A city governed by a sinister artificial intelligence seemed an appropriate place to submit my expense account. Surely a machine would appreciate the mathematical inevitability of a gold-plated stamp. Shawna said that an oppressive computer and a competent accountant were different problems, and mine could be solved by either one saying no.

Robert Foster arrived in Union City with a robot friend's circuit board and a much more serious reason to distrust authority. I arrived with a printer cartridge and a petty grievance. Tank suggested that, should we be abducted into a dystopia, my first priority ought to be escape rather than requesting a corner office.

Mercedes placed our office rules beside the game file. There were forty-seven. Rosa removed forty-six, leaving ASK BEFORE BORROWING SOMEONE'S CHAIR. I considered this a dangerous weakening of institutional power. Everyone sat down more happily, which made my position surprisingly difficult to defend.

The actual attraction

This is the original 1994 adventure: Robert Foster is taken into a city under authoritarian machine control, accompanied by the circuit board of his robot friend. Its appeal is a bleak science-fiction setting with room for satirical personality and practical investigation.

The catch worth knowing

This older adventure's interface, object logic and navigation deserve a direct trial. Abduction, violence and oppressive institutions shape the story. The developer page does not establish a death-free or untimed complete path, and its mobile release details must not be transferred to the original PC game.

An opening invitation

Inspect the first accessible environment and identify the immediate objective without trying to cover the whole city. Check how examining and using an object differ, then decide whether that interaction makes sense in practice.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admit for a taste of dystopian mystery when old adventure conventions sound interesting. Deny any city computer permission to interpret my stationery budget as a model for civilization.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Revolution identifies original release 1994, Foster, Union City and the AI premise. The card targets original PC, not the later mobile edition or Beyond a Steel Sky. Complete timing/death/hold behavior remains unverified.

Source 1: https://revolution.co.uk/games_catalog/beneath-a-steel-sky/

P029 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Kathy Rain: Director's Cut

Journalism Has Asked to See My Sources

Edition considered: PC Director's Cut

Kathy Rain had a motorcycle, a notebook and a family mystery. I had a swivel chair, a monogrammed pen and a theory about who kept lowering my chair. The similarities were obvious until Mercedes asked whether I had interviewed anybody other than myself. I said that narrowing the source pool reduced inconsistency.

Shawna raised the chair. 'There. Investigative breakthrough.' I lowered my voice and explained that the chair might be a symptom of a much larger pattern. Rosa handed me Kathy's file, where a grandfather's death and the past of a small town actually justified serious questions.

The notebook appealed to me. Evidence should have somewhere to live besides the back of a shopping receipt. Tank supplied a clean one, then confiscated my proposed cover: TRUTHS TOO LARGE FOR ORDINARY PEOPLE. He wrote NOTES. I protested that the title lacked atmosphere. 'It leaves space for facts,' he said.

The actual attraction

Kathy's investigation connects her grandfather's death, family history and the secrets of a small town. The Director's Cut expands the original mystery and advertises a single-click mouse interface, making the combination of investigative conversation and a clear protagonist worth examining.

The catch worth knowing

A simpler click interface does not remove puzzle memory or emotional intensity. Family trauma and disturbing material matter here. The source does not settle every late chase, timer or held-input requirement. This is specifically Director's Cut, not an assumption that the 2016 original behaves identically.

An opening invitation

Read the initial context and try one conversation with Kathy's notebook close at hand. Assess both the single-click interaction and whether this family mystery feels compelling today; neither decision requires completing a case.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider when a sharp, adult protagonist and a troubled hometown sound like good company. The Bureau authorizes an ordinary notebook and withdraws my twelve-word title from circulation immediately.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Director's Cut listing supports single-click interface, expanded story and family investigation. It is not a full-path accessibility audit; late required timing and holds remain unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1395030/>

P030 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Whispers of a Machine

My Personality Upgrade Requires a Reboot

Edition considered: PC release

Vera's abilities responded to her approach to people, which I considered an excellent argument for equipping me with advanced investigative technology. Mercedes asked which upgrade corresponded to making a speech while someone else fixed the problem. 'Strategic presence,' I said. She searched the imaginary menu and found nothing.

Whispers of a Machine offered a cybernetic investigator whose choices could change how she solved things. I announced my three available approaches: Magnificent, Extremely Magnificent, and Waiting for Applause. Shawna added a fourth: LISTEN. This generated more applause than I had budgeted for.

Tank brought me a headset made from two paper cups. 'Prototype empathy augmentation.' I put it on and heard Rosa asking whether anybody wanted tea. For once I answered the actual question before developing a theory about it. The technology was crude, but the results suggested a promising future for the entire institution.

The actual attraction

Vera investigates murders in a Nordic science-fiction world where forbidden technology and personal history intersect. Her responses influence the augmentations available for solving problems, connecting the detective's character to the practical shape of the investigation.

The catch worth knowing

Different abilities, dialogue approaches and possible solutions create more to remember than a single straightforward clue chain. The premise includes violence and grief. The inspected listing does not establish every required timer or held gesture, so character depth should not be mistaken for a simple interface promise.

An opening invitation

Follow an early conversation and choose the response that feels natural, then inspect how the game explains Vera's available abilities. Write down one ability in plain language instead of trying to optimize an entire personality.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admit if the idea of a detective's temperament influencing her methods sounds intriguing. Paper-cup empathy upgrades remain available in the lobby, provided I stop talking long enough for them to work.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher listing supports Vera, cybernetic abilities shaped by responses, voiced dialogue and multiple puzzle solutions. Memory rating is editorial; full-path timing and input requirements are unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/631570/>

P031 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Kathy Rain 2: Soothsayer

The Detective Budget Has Finally Found a Plot

Edition considered: PC release

Kathy Rain's next investigation began with a financial problem, which made her immediately relatable to the Bureau's treasurer. I explained that our deficit was an investment in future authority. Shawna pointed at the invoice for embossed folders. 'Your future authority has ordered the wrong size.' I called that a bold rejection of conventional filing.

The Soothsayer case promised Kathy a way out of money trouble and into something considerably worse. Mercedes asked whether I could distinguish a compelling fictional predicament from a sensible household budgeting strategy. I could, although the distinction did damage to my proposed detective-reward revenue forecast.

Rosa slid a plain envelope across the desk. It contained enough for ordinary paper and a note saying NO MORE GOLD EDGES. I found the restraint moving. Tank found the arithmetic easier. We gave Kathy the dangerous case and gave me the equally appropriate challenge of operating within one envelope.

The actual attraction

The sequel follows Kathy in 1998 as a private investigator drawn into the Soothsayer serial-killer case. Its appeal is an established adult lead facing a larger city, new people and a case that ties professional ambition to immediate financial stakes.

The catch worth knowing

A larger investigation means more names, locations and clues, even with a notebook to organize them. Serial murder brings dark material. The inspected store page establishes the story and notebook, not a guarantee about all late timing or input sequences. Director's Cut findings do not automatically apply to this sequel.

An opening invitation

Read Kathy's opening situation and investigate one available lead. Use the notebook to summarize what the lead means, then judge whether the sequel's mood and interface invite another conversation rather than another obligation.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider when you want to follow Kathy into a bigger case, not because a larger budget promises simpler play. My envelope system remains available at a much smaller dramatic scale.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact 2025 sequel listing supports 1998 setting, financial premise, Soothsayer investigation and notebook. All-path timing and held inputs remain unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1466390/>

P032 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Tangle Tower

The Painting Would Like a Lawyer

Edition considered: PC release

A murder mystery in which a painted figure appeared to be implicated seemed designed to rehabilitate my reception portrait. 'At last,' I told Mercedes, 'proof that artwork can possess agency.' She said the only agency my portrait possessed was making people choose a different chair. I filed that as a hostile witness statement.

Tangle Tower supplied a strange mansion, a peculiar family and a very inconvenient crime scene. I supplied a tiny paper lawyer to stand beside my frame. Shawna asked why the lawyer looked like me. I explained that legal representation required trust. 'Then your painting needs a second opinion.'

Tank turned the portrait toward the wall while Rosa opened the actual mystery. The painted suspects had better expressions, the investigators had better questions, and the mansion had better lighting. I withdrew my objection. A detective game should be permitted to outshine the office decor without triggering a constitutional crisis.

The actual attraction

Grimoire and Sally investigate Freya Fellow's death in a mansion where a painting appears entangled in the crime. A fully voiced, animated cast and richly drawn rooms make conversation and character observation a large part of the appeal.

The catch worth knowing

The current PC listing declares mouse-only play, play without timed input and saving at any time. Those declarations are useful but do not establish comfortable dragging or manipulation of every puzzle object. Remembering family relationships and comparing testimony still require attention; an untimed mystery can be a substantial mystery.

An opening invitation

Speak with one suspect and inspect one object closely enough to test selection and any manipulation. Decide whether the voices, expressions and room details make you want to ask a second question.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A promising first stop for an eccentric, theatrical investigation with encouraging declared pacing. The painting may retain counsel; my self-portrait must continue representing itself on a strictly unpaid basis.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact PC listing supports premise, voices and developer-declared Mouse Only, Playable without Timed Input and Save Anytime. Gesture comfort and complete-path suitability have not been independently tested.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/359510/>

P033 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Detective Grimoire

The Swamp Monster Has Better Visitor Facilities

Edition considered: 2014 PC commercial game; not Flash original

I proposed that the Bureau open a swamp attraction. Tank asked whether the swamp existed. I pointed to the damp patch beneath my abandoned noir raincoat. 'We start small.' Mercedes said that charging admission to an office maintenance problem was an unusually pure expression of my business instincts.

Detective Grimoire's case concerned a real attraction within its fictional swamp, a dead owner and a creature everybody seemed ready to suspect. I admired the efficiency of a community arriving with its own suspect. Shawna admired nothing about that sentence and made me read the word EVIDENCE aloud.

Rosa shut our attraction before opening day by hanging up the raincoat. I protested that a unique cultural opportunity had been lost. Tank placed a paper sign beside the dry floor: MONSTER NOT CONFIRMED. It was the most honest advertising the Bureau had produced all week, and therefore completely unsuitable for my original campaign.

The actual attraction

The commercial 2014 Detective Grimoire builds a compact murder investigation around an odd swamp attraction and its inhabitants. Interviews and assembled conclusions give the detective's reasoning a visible role, while the creature rumors invite questions about what people assume and why.

The catch worth knowing

This is the paid standalone game, not the earlier browser title. Its mouse/touch-oriented design still involves connecting ideas and handling puzzle interfaces. The inspected listing does not explicitly verify that every sequence is untimed or that no drag-and-hold gesture is required; check the actual build before treating it as a sure fit.

An opening invitation

Meet an early witness and try forming one small conclusion from the available ideas. Observe whether selecting and joining those ideas feels natural, without imposing a deadline for reaching the correct answer.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider when an eccentric little suspect community sounds appealing. Any swamp attraction founded by me requires independent plumbing inspection before the Bureau will permit the word tourism on its paperwork.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

The 2014 commercial game's Steam listing supports the swamp case, voiced cast, conclusion system and mouse/touch design. Complete timing and held-gesture requirements are not verified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/272600/>

P034 / CONDITIONAL / text input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

The Roottrees are Dead

A Family Tree with a Very Ambitious Root

Edition considered: 2025 Steam remake; not free browser original

I began our genealogy session by placing my own photograph at the top of the family tree. Shawna asked whether I was claiming to be everyone's ancestor. 'Symbolically.' Mercedes moved the photograph to a separate sheet titled UNRELATED FUNDING APPLICANT. This was hostile, but the diagram became easier to read.

The Roottrees investigation involved inheritance, blood relationships and an early internet full of clues. I offered to improve the family's public image for a modest fictional retainer. Rosa pointed out that identifying a person and liking a person were different tasks. Tank pointed out that my retainer consisted of the last chocolate biscuit.

We started with one confirmed relationship instead of my forty-seven speculative branches. Suddenly the tree looked like evidence rather than a climbing frame for my ego. I reclaimed the biscuit under a newly discovered legal principle: if nobody hires the consultant, he may still eat his own lunch.

The actual attraction

The 2025 remake turns a wealthy family's genealogy into an investigation through a simulated 1998 internet. Photographs, articles and other fragments gradually identify people and their relationships, making the central reward the moment scattered information clicks into a coherent family tree.

The catch worth knowing

Names, generations, visual identification and search terms create a heavy memory and reading load. Typing and navigating the information interface matter more than reflexes in the described core activity, but that does not certify every input as effortless. This remake differs from the free 2023 browser original.

An opening invitation

Identify one person using one clearly connected source, then place or record that single relationship. A separate scratch note can hold a name while you test the search and family-tree interface without filling the whole chart.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admit for someone who enjoys following documentary threads and can tolerate a busy evidence web. Reject my attempt to inherit merely by occupying the diagram's largest available rectangle with confidence.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact 2025 Steam remake listing supports early-internet research, family-tree deduction and rebuilt interface. The memory assessment is editorial; no universal timing/hold guarantee is inferred from the genre.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2754380/>

P035 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

The Rise of the Golden Idol

The Seventies Have Requested a Wider Collar

Edition considered: PC base game

I wore a large-collared shirt to receive The Rise of the Golden Idol. Mercedes said the collar entered the room several seconds before I did. I told her historical immersion required commitment. Tank asked whether the shirt needed its own chair. It did, but I refused to dignify the question with a seating chart.

The game's strange chain of crimes and coincidences belonged to the 1970s, two centuries beyond its predecessor. I proposed that my shirt was therefore valid primary evidence. Shawna said clothing could establish a mood without establishing a fact, a distinction that ruined at least half my public appearances.

Rosa put one case before us. One scene, some people, something that did not add up. My collar stopped being the most interesting object in the room. This was a severe institutional setback and an excellent sign for the game, which had achieved it without appointing a single wardrobe committee.

The actual attraction

A new era gives the Golden Idol deduction format fresh social scenery: investigators piece together strange events involving crime, belief and institutional ambition. The game invites close reading of scenes and reconstructing what happened rather than steering an action hero through them.

The catch worth knowing

The publisher explicitly describes exploring scenes at your own pace. That supports unhurried observation, not low complexity: names, collected words, connections across cases and chapter-level deductions can become dense. Input comfort and any required dragging still need a local check; dark crime scenes are central.

An opening invitation

Open the first case, inspect a small cluster of connected clues, and try stating aloud what seems to have happened before filling every answer. Leave the broader conspiracy for another sitting if the first scene is enough.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A promising choice for patient deduction when a puzzle-rich mystery sounds pleasurable. The Bureau accepts no claim that a wider shirt collar provides a wider evidentiary perspective or additional deduction slots.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher description supports 1970s setting, twenty cases and exploration at the player's pace. The waits label refers to scene investigation, not a tested blanket guarantee about every input or comfort need.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2716400/>

P036 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Gabriel Knight: Sins of the Fathers 20th Anniversary Edition

The Bookshop Owner Declines My Autobiography

Edition considered: PC 20th Anniversary Edition

A novelist running a bookshop while investigating sinister murders struck me as a man with the correct number of simultaneous occupations. I offered Gabriel Knight my autobiography for his shelves. Mercedes asked whether it had an ending. 'History is ongoing.' She said this was also a problem with my staff meetings.

New Orleans supplied a setting full of atmosphere, while the mystery drew Gabriel toward his family's past. I supplied a stack of imaginary signed copies. Tank used them to level the wobbly table. For the first time my collected wisdom had produced an immediate, measurable improvement to somebody's day.

Shawna insisted we identify the exact game: the twentieth-anniversary remake, not the old release with assumptions taped over it. Rosa added that a dark story could be compelling without becoming tonight's obligation. I agreed and shortened my book signing to no books, no queue and one grateful table.

The actual attraction

Gabriel's investigation of ritual murders draws a writer and bookshop owner into a family mystery in New Orleans. The twentieth-anniversary edition retells the first game with rebuilt presentation and additional material, offering a strong dose of place, conversation and supernatural noir.

The catch worth knowing

The story includes murder, horror and fictionalized religious material. Adventure puzzles can demand inventory reasoning and remembered conversations. This remake's complete path has not been checked for every dangerous or timed passage; do not assume its modern presentation removes the original design's possible pressure points.

An opening invitation

Try one early conversation or bookshop interaction and see whether Gabriel's personality and the setting appeal. Check the interface at the same time, keeping the first objective small rather than committing to the entire supernatural history.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admit conditionally for an atmospheric adult mystery with literary ambitions. My autobiography may remain beneath the table until it proves a more useful clue than a furniture repair technique ever should.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact twentieth-anniversary Steam edition supports Gabriel, New Orleans, murders and added remake material. Complete timing and held-input requirements remain unverified; fictional portrayals are not presented as cultural research.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/262000/>

P037 / DETOUR / mixed input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

Still Life

Two Investigators and One Unqualified Art Critic

Edition considered: 2005 PC original

I thought Still Life might qualify as a pleasant afternoon discussing fruit bowls. Mercedes opened the dossier. 'Serial murder.' I turned my proposed wine-and-cheese reception into a much quieter tea service. A title, it appeared, could not be trusted to perform the entire work of content screening for me.

The investigation crossed between Victoria in Chicago and an earlier case involving her grandfather in Prague. I constructed a family timeline with two photographs and an extremely expensive piece of string. Shawna asked why the string was expensive. I explained that it had been sold as exhibition cord. She explained that it remained string.

Rosa read the later control warning and kept it attached to the front. The grim crime story and the timing-dependent robot puzzle belonged in the same recommendation. I wanted a tidier verdict. Tank said a tidy verdict purchased by hiding the awkward part was just my usual filing system with better stationery.

The actual attraction

Two related investigations in different places and eras create the appeal: a contemporary FBI case and a grandfather's earlier work gradually echo one another. This is a dark serial-crime adventure for someone specifically interested in disturbing mysteries and historical connections.

The catch worth knowing

A contemporary review describes a required robot-and-laser puzzle that depends on timing even though it is not a simple countdown. That materially conflicts with a strict no-rush preference. Graphic crime material and layered puzzle logic add further demands; this is a clearly marked detour, not an easy recommendation.

An opening invitation

Start by considering the subject matter and the documented later timing obstacle. If both are acceptable with a chosen helper or shared-viewing arrangement, inspect an early investigation scene without interpreting it as the whole game's control profile.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Retain for deliberate dark-mystery browsing only, with the laser warning visible. The Bureau's fruit-bowl reception is cancelled, and its title-screen assumptions have been placed under professional supervision for the afternoon.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher listing establishes the original game's dual-era crime premise. GameBoomers' contemporary review specifically reports timing-dependent robot/laser movement. No claim that this obstacle has an accessible skip is made.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/46480/>

Source 2: <https://www.gameboomers.com/reviews/Ss/Stilllifebynickie.htm>

P038 / CONDITIONAL / mixed input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

Grim Fandango Remastered

The Department of Death Has a Better Travel Desk

Edition considered: PC Remastered edition

Manny Calavera sold travel arrangements for the dead, which suggested a clientele less likely to complain about my opening speeches. Rosa asked whether I had learned anything at all from hospitality. I clarified that I admired the dramatic premise, not the business opportunity.

Mercedes wrote that clarification down in case I needed it again.

Grim Fandango's afterlife bureaucracy had stylish suits and a corruption problem. Our Bureau had an ill-fitting blazer and a laminator. I proposed a merger on the grounds of shared institutional themes. Shawna said the game already contained enough compromised administrators without importing one whose main scandal involved commemorative coasters.

Tank played an imaginary trumpet flourish as I put the merger file away. The music, the noir atmosphere, the strange journey: these were actual reasons to look at Manny's world. I allowed them to speak for themselves, a management innovation so radical that Rosa checked whether I had a sore throat.

The actual attraction

Manny's journey through a noir-inflected land of the dead combines memorable characters, an unusual visual world and a rich musical identity. The remaster refreshes presentation while preserving the adventure's central pleasure: a compromised little job opening into a much larger story.

The catch worth knowing

Traditional inventory puzzles and indirect solution logic can require considerable memory and hints. The developer confirms additional control schemes, but that alone does not establish comfortable movement or every timing requirement. Check the PC controls in practice; do not import PlayStation button instructions or assume remaster means simplified puzzles.

An opening invitation

Explore Manny's first available workplace interactions, compare the installed control choices, and test movement between two nearby points. Let the voice and atmosphere win your interest before agreeing to carry a long inventory of unsolved errands.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider for a stylish, characterful adventure when unusual puzzle logic sounds welcome. Deny the Bureau's merger proposal: the afterlife has enough paperwork without my commemorative stationery subsidiary seeking permanent office space.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

PC listing supports premise and remastered presentation; Double Fine confirms additional control schemes. Full control comfort and all-path timing are unverified. No native co-op is inferred from Remote Play Together metadata.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/316790/>

Source 2: <https://www.doublefine.com/news/grim-fandango-remastered-pre-orders-now-available>

P039 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: no

Thimbleweed Park

The Town Where Everybody Deserves a Separate Folder

Edition considered: PC release

Thimbleweed Park offered five playable people in a town with more secrets than ordinary municipal planning would recommend. I issued five folders. Mercedes opened hers and found my photograph in all of them. 'A filing error,' I said. Shawna said it was a consistent filing policy and therefore worse.

A strange town, a dead body, a haunted hotel and an abandoned circus gave the investigation plenty to work with. I suggested adding a Bureau visitor center. Tank asked whether it would contain a bathroom or simply a sixth suspicious man. I promised an informative brochure, which answered neither question.

Rosa selected the idea of a smaller first task and made me put the other folders aside. One character could inspect one place before we tried to understand an entire town. This struck me as offensively sensible. I preserved the five-folder set for later, after removing the portrait inserts and the unnecessary ribbon.

The actual attraction

An eccentric 1987 town ties together five playable characters and an increasingly strange mystery. The attraction is ensemble comedy, peculiar locations and the satisfaction of uncovering connections while a traditional adventure keeps revealing another layer of oddness.

The catch worth knowing

The publisher offers Casual and Hard modes and describes exploration at your own pace. Casual is the more relevant first trial, but it does not make five characters, inventories and ongoing objectives trivial. Interface gestures and any exceptional sequence still need checking; selecting a difficulty is not a universal no-hold guarantee.

An opening invitation

Choose Casual and follow one character's immediate objective. Try one conversation and one object interaction, noting whether the action interface is clear before switching people or collecting a large list of unfinished tasks.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Consider for a strange ensemble mystery with a useful lower-puzzle-load starting choice. The Bureau may issue multiple folders only after proving that each one contains somebody other than me this time.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher listing supports five playable characters, Casual/Hard modes and exploring at one's pace. Casual is an editorial first-trial choice, not proof that every interaction or entire path meets all preferences.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/569860/>

P040 / DETOUR / mixed input / pace: mixed / native co-op: no

Full Throttle Remastered

The Motorcycle Cannot Be Driven by Reputation

Edition considered: PC Remastered edition

I borrowed a leather jacket to introduce Full Throttle. Tank asked whether I could ride a motorcycle. I said I possessed the bearing. He placed a kitchen stool in front of me and requested a safe demonstration of mounting it. The jacket caught on the armrest. My bearing required assistance.

Ben and the Polecats inhabited a tale of motorcycles, corporate trouble and murder. I inhabited a tale of one sleeve refusing to release me. Mercedes watched Shawna untangle it and said this was an unusually faithful preview of why style and mechanical demands needed separate paragraphs.

The game had action sequences, including its road material, alongside adventure puzzles. Rosa kept that fact beside the glorious engine noise. I finally stood up, returned the jacket and approved a detour label. A person could admire a biker story without being recruited into its driving requirements, particularly after the stool had won the opening encounter decisively.

The actual attraction

Ben's trouble with powerful interests unfolds through a compact biker adventure full of distinctive characters, visual attitude and rock music. The remaster restores the original game's presentation and adds archival material, preserving a very particular kind of animated road-movie energy.

The catch worth knowing

This is not solely unhurried conversation and inventory work. Its remastered road sequences retain active gameplay, and the adventure includes action demands. A complete no-reflex route or universal skip has not been verified here. Treat it as a deliberate detour if required timing is unwelcome.

An opening invitation

Watch or try an early quiet conversation to judge the tone, while keeping the later action warning visible. Decide separately whether someone wants to handle those sequences; shared help is an arrangement, not native cooperative play.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Keep when the cast and biker atmosphere justify a consciously chosen detour. A leather jacket, however persuasive, cannot satisfy the control check or overturn the kitchen stool's recorded victory in single combat.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Double Fine supports the remastered game's premise; the platform interview with Tim Schafer confirms the playable Mine Road sequence's preservation. No unverified skip/no-action route is claimed.

Source 1: <https://www.doublefine.com/games/full-throttle-remastered>

Source 2: <https://blog.playstation.com/archive/2017/01/13/how-double-fine-is-tuning-up-full-throttle-remastered-for-ps4/>

The Case of the Guest Who Simply Picked Something

I had prepared a closing ceremony. There would be a ribbon, a brief speech, and a photograph in which I appeared to have personally invented leisure. Tank had practiced releasing a handful of paper stars from behind the filing cabinet. He had practiced too enthusiastically. We were finding stars in the sandwich tray, the printer, and one of the mystery files. 'Atmosphere,' he said. Rosa removed a silver star from a tomato. 'Paper.' He considered this distinction without conceding it. Shawna reviewed the ceremony. 'Where does someone actually choose a game?' I showed her the final box on the flowchart. 'After the remarks.' 'How long are the remarks?' 'Depends how the audience responds.' Mercedes took the chart and drew a new arrow from the entrance directly to a chair. 'There.' 'That bypasses the whole department.' 'I know. Beautiful work.' The arrow was not gold. It had no embossed border. It performed its function with humiliating economy.

What mattered had become embarrassingly clear. One person might want a ghost who talks too much; another might prefer a courtroom contradiction, a strange plant, or a lawyer whose business trip goes spectacularly off schedule. Even the right premise could meet the wrong evening. A short first encounter was enough to learn something. A control check could reveal a catch before the story became a commitment. A decision to stop did not require a report, a reason, or an apology to the folder.

I put the flowchart away. Not because Mercedes had won. Because, after careful leadership, I had decided that her idea should be allowed to resemble my policy. Tank asked whether the closing speech was canceled. I said postponed. 'Until what?' 'Until an appropriate occasion.' 'Printer jam?' 'Possibly.' He nodded. He had learned the diplomatic art of leaving a man one harmless illusion while unplugging the microphone.

The room grew quieter. Somebody opened a game. A line appeared, somebody laughed, and the table stopped being the most interesting thing in it. I watched for a moment without interrupting. Shawna rested her hand on my shoulder. 'You found some good possibilities.' That pleased me more than the photograph would have. I nearly said so. Then the printer made a grinding noise and delivered the first page of my canceled speech across the floor.

Tank picked it up. 'Distinguished delegates of pleasure - ' 'Private draft.' ' - through my tireless leadership - ' 'Give me that.' Rosa took the page, turned it over, and wrote the next useful question on the blank side: what sounded fun? She set it where everyone could reach it. No timer, no required sequence, no demand to justify an answer. A question small enough to belong on one piece of paper. I had built a department around it. My friends, with considerable difficulty, had let the question survive.

An index with no authority over you

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Credits, source limits and the paperwork we actually mean

Creative direction: Nolan. Original Panorama prose, system design, research compilation and production: ChatGPT. A new companion experiment using the user-directed Ten Toes Down characters; the existing novels remain intact. Dedicated to Lillian and to the pleasure of finding something worth another turn.

Voice sources sampled: the revised Ten Toes Down six-book edition, especially Book I's funeral opening and Book II's academy arrival, plus the repository editorial record. Repository snapshot: 4f38948aa5fa97f294adfa74a0b7055c399b2826. The complete novels were not reread line by line for this project.

The optional traits, tokens and signed-dice layer take inspiration from Fate. The Panorama's catalogue coordinates, vetoes, snack amendment, incidents and appeals are original comic selection rules; this is not a substitute for the Fate rulebooks.

Fate reference pages consulted:

<https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/how-do-stuff-outcomes-actions-and-approaches> and <https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/aspects-fate-points>. No Fate logos, illustrations or fonts are used.

This work is based on Fate Core System and Fate Accelerated Edition, products of Evil Hat Productions, LLC, developed, authored, and edited by Leonard Balsera, Brian Engard, Jeremy Keller, Ryan Macklin, Mike Olson, Clark Valentine, Amanda Valentine, Fred Hicks, and Rob Donoghue, and licensed for our use under the Creative Commons Attribution 3.0 Unported license (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/>).

Game titles identify the corresponding games. No game code, ROMs, full manuals or third-party artwork are included. Availability and controls can vary by edition, region and platform. The sources support their stated claims; no purchase, installation or personal fit has been established by this book.

Each case names its inspected sources and the limits of those sources. Store descriptions and developer feature declarations are not a playthrough of every route. The companion evidence ledger records editorial tags separately from source declarations. Availability and features may change after the check date.